

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On this occasion, BJP National President Nitin Nabin, accompanied by Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra, Organisation General Secretary Pawan Rana, MP Bansuri Swaraj, Karol Bagh District President Virendra Babbar, and local councillor



the Piniirapole Gaushala in Kishanganj and offered prayers on the temple premises, followed by the recitation of Sunderkand. During her visit, she toured the gaushala and participated in traditional worship by offering fodder to cows. After offering



level. Delhi Minister Pravesh Verma reached the Hanuman Temple at Connaught Place

BJP National Vice President and MP Baijayant Jay Panda attended a special prayer ceremony and Maha Aarti at Shri Shiv Shakti Temple in R.K. Puram. MLA Anil Sharma, party workers, and well-



BJP National General Secretary Sunil Bansal participated in special prayers and Maha Aarti at the 108-foot Hanuman Temple. Delhi BJP General Secretary Vishnu Mittal was also present. BJP National General Secretary

obesance at Gurudwara Shri Bangla Sahib, Delhi BJP Minister Sardar Imprit Singh Bakhshi accompanied him. BJP National General Secretary Dushyant Gautam prayed for a prosperous India under Prime Minister Modi's leadership at Siddh Hanuman

Delhi Ministers Ashish Sood, Kapil Mishra, Indraraj Singh, and Pankaj Singh offered prayers for the Prime Minister's success at Arya Samaj Mandir Janakpuri, Hanuman Mandir Connaught Place, ISKCON Temple Rohini, and Chhath Puja Hanuman Temple Kunwar Singh Nagar, respectively. Delhi Environment Minister Sarla Devi Manjinder Singh Sirsa offered prayers at Brahmin Samaj Temple, Rajouri Garden.

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
 ■ New Delhi

The banners on the streets of Delhi carried PM Modi in multiple avatars. One

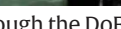


and public welfare). The headquarters entrance was laid with a red carpet, flanked by roll-up standees carrying Modi's photograph. Other standees at the headquarters carried specific governance themes: one read

Prime Minister Modi crossed the 4,399-day mark on June 10, overtaking Nehru's elected tenure of 4,398 consecutive days after the country's first general election. While Indira Gandhi served for more than 14 years in office, her tenure was not continuous, making Modi the longest continuously serving elected Prime Minister in the country's history.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Parents seeking admission for their children will be required to submit online



It said if the number of eligible applicants for a class is

tions.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The e-Auction offered 142 properties and land assets across Delhi, comprising residential, commercial, industrial and institutional plots, group housing sites, commercial estate built-up shops, multilevel parking facilities, kiosks and other licence-fee-based assets

A commercial plot at Karkardooma (21-22 Pocket) attracted 36 bidders and achieved a value of more than ten times its reserve price. Another institutional plot at Karkardooma (Plot No. 3A) emerged as the most actively bid property in the

The competitive bidding witnessed across multiple asset categories, coupled with the substantial premium achieved over reserve prices, highlights the growing market appeal of DDA's land and property assets and demonstrates the effectiveness of transparent electronic auctions in

It also said the DDA will continue to bring such opportunities to the people through transparent and competitive processes, enabling wider participation in Delhi's growth story while fostering planned, inclusive and sustainable urban development.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The drive focused on major arterial roads, market areas, footpaths, service lanes, parking influence zones and other traffic-sensitive locations where encroachments and illegal parking were disrupting traffic flow and posing safety risks.



The authorities also removed 1,264 encroachments, such as temporary

"In the first phase, enforcement efforts were concentrated around six

"The campaign was necessitated by the increasing impact of encroachments and improper parking on road safety, pedestrian mobility and emergency response operations," the officer added.



DDA

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• Ready-to-move-in Flats

• Freehold Property

• Sample Flats open for visit

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Actual Site Photograph

IN FOCUS



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday upheld the Returning Officer's decision to reject the Rajya Sabha nomination of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan from Madhya Pradesh, prompting the party to announce that it will challenge the decision in the Supreme Court.

A 10-member Congress delegation met Election Commission officials in New Delhi and sought intervention in the matter. The delegation included senior leaders Abhishek Manu Singhvi, K.C. Venugopal, Jairam Ramesh, Randeep Surjewala, Sachin Pilot, Bhupesh Baghel and Vivek Tankha.

According to Congress leaders, after hearing arguments from the party delegation, the Election Commission reserved its decision for about two hours. At around 5.30 pm, the Commission informed the party that it found no fault with the Returning Officer's order and upheld



Congress leader KC Venugopal addressing the media as party leaders Vivek Tankha, and Meenakshi Natarajan after a meeting with the EC at Nirvachan Sadan, in New Delhi

the rejection of Natarajan's nomination. Addressing the media after the meeting, Singhvi said the Returning Officer's decision was legally unsustainable and based on grounds not recognised under election law. He

argued that Natarajan was not required to disclose the matter cited against her because it was not a criminal case.

According to Singhvi, the Hyderabad court had merely issued

a notice seeking her response on whether further proceedings should be initiated, and no criminal charges had been framed against her. The controversy began after election officials rejected Natarajan's nomination during scrutiny, citing alleged irregularities in her affidavit. The BJP had objected to her nomination, alleging that she failed to disclose details of a matter pending before a Hyderabad court.

With the Election Commission refusing to overturn the Returning Officer's order, Congress leaders said the party would now approach the Supreme Court seeking relief. The party maintains that the rejection of its candidate's nomination is contrary to law and has described the decision as an attack on democratic principles.

Meanwhile, Congress workers continued protests in Bhopal, accusing the BJP of influencing the electoral process and alleging that the Rajya Sabha seat had been unfairly taken away from the opposition.

NHRC notice to Gujarat Govt over Surat septic tank deaths

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The NHRC on Wednesday said it has issued a notice to the Gujarat Government and police authorities over reports that four workers died allegedly after inhaling toxic fumes while cleaning a septic tank at a jewellery manufacturing unit in Surat district.

They entered the tank to clean it "without following any safety protocol" and became victims of toxic fumes. The workers were taken to the hospital by the rescue team, where doctors declared them dead, the National Human Rights Commission said in a statement. The human rights panel said it has taken "suo motu cognisance of a media report that on June 7, four workers died while cleaning a septic tank at a jewellery manufacturing unit in Surat district of Gujarat".

The commission has observed that the content of the news report, if true, raises serious issues of violation of human rights.

Therefore, it has issued notices to Gujarat's chief secretary and Surat's commissioner of police, seeking a detailed report on it in two weeks. The report is expected to include the status of the investigation and compensation, if any, paid to the next of kin of the deceased workers, the statement said.

According to the media report, carried on June 8, the waste generated during the jewellery cleaning process is collected in the septic tank, it said.



CM Yogi directs faster action against economic crimes, stronger EOW through technology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday directed the Economic Offences Wing to further intensify action against financial crimes and ensure speedy investigation, prosecution and conviction in cases involving fraud, embezzlement and other economic offences.

Reviewing the functioning and progress of the EOW, the chief minister, according to an official statement, stressed the need for swift disposal of pending cases and effective action against wanted accused persons.

He said economic crimes not only affect Government resources but also undermine public trust, making it imperative to ensure strict and time-bound action against offenders.

During the meeting, officials reviewed pending investigations, arrests, prosecution efforts, public awareness initiatives and organisational reforms related to economic offences.

According to officials, the EOW disposed of 155 investigations, inquiries and follow-up proceedings till May 31 this year. During the same period, 71 accused persons were arrested. Directing officials to expedite the disposal of old cases and



strengthen efforts to apprehend wanted accused, Adityanath emphasised the need to accelerate prosecution and judicial proceedings in cases where sufficient evidence is available.

He also directed officials to make effective use of the technology-driven platform, saying it would improve transparency, accountability and the quality of investigations. He also ordered regular monitoring of important cases to ensure offenders are brought to justice. Officials informed the meeting that a Case Management System (CMS) has been developed for effective management of investigations and related proceedings. The system provides digital case management, online reporting, real-time monitoring and dashboard-based supervision. He also instructed that investigating officers should not

retain any case for more than three months and that accountability be fixed in such instances.

Highlighting the importance of public awareness in preventing economic offences, he said people should be educated about financial fraud, investment scams and other emerging forms of economic crime in the changing technological environment.

Officials said the EOW is running a public outreach campaign titled "Awareness, Information, Protection" to educate citizens about safeguarding themselves against economic offences.

Adityanath directed that the campaign be expanded further. He also stressed the use of technology in training programmes dealing with Ponzi schemes, multi-level marketing frauds, chit fund scams and cyber fraud. The meeting also discussed proposals related to capacity building, training of officers and investigators, adoption of modern technologies and expansion of the organisation.

He said the nature of economic crimes is becoming increasingly complex and stressed the need to equip investigating agencies with modern resources, technological expertise and efficient systems to effectively curb such offences.

Noida Airport conducts full-scale turnaround trial with IndiGo

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Noida

Noida International Airport on Wednesday said it has successfully conducted a full-scale aircraft turnaround trial as part of its operational readiness, activation and transition (ORAT) programme ahead of the commencement of commercial operations.

According to a statement issued by the airport, the trial was conducted on June 9 in collaboration with IndiGo and key airport partners to simulate a complete aircraft turnaround process on the airside.

The greefield airport is set to commence commercial operations with domestic flights from June 15.

The exercise tested coordination between various systems, processes and stakeholders, including critical airport infrastructure, such as visual docking guidance systems (VDGS), passenger boarding bridges and ground power systems.



VDGS is an automated airport display system to guide pilots to safely and precisely park their aircraft at the terminal gate.

The trial also covered integrated baggage handling, cargo operations, in-flight catering and other ground handling activities, while refuelling scenarios were evaluated as part of operational preparedness, the statement said. Re-validation of the

Instrument Landing System (ILS) and Required Navigation Performance (RNP) approach procedures was also carried out during the exercise, it added.

The airport said the turnaround trial was part of a series of advanced ORAT exercises aimed at ensuring seamless coordination across operational interfaces before the start of commercial operations.

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PM sharpens attack on Congress

"Unfortunately, however, in 2004, the country was once again caught in a vortex of instability and the stranglehold of the Congress. It dragged the country into multi-crore rupee scams. It should have been named Congress growth rate," the prime minister said.

PM Modi was speaking at a NDA conclave to celebrate his milestone in surpassing Jawaharlal Nehru's record to become India's longest-serving elected PM. Chief Ministers of NDA ruled states including N Chandrababu Naidu were present on the occasion beside members of Union Cabinet from the alliance.

NDA leaders congratulated Modi on becoming the longest continuously serving elected Prime Minister and resolved to continue working towards the goal of a Viksit Bharat under his leadership.

In a resolution passed at a day-long conclave here, the ruling alliance hailed Modi's "visionary leadership and tireless dedication to public service" and said his governance model is responsive to citizens, innovative in its approach and transformative in its impact, in the true spirit of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas'. Under Prime Minister Modi's leadership, the defining character of the last 12 years has been the seamless integration of people-centric development, participative democracy and performance-oriented governance, it said. "The National Democratic Alliance expresses its deepest gratitude to the people of India for their continued trust and support. It congratulates Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his visionary leadership and tireless dedication to public service," the resolution said.

In his 37-minute speech largely focused on his government's achievements in the last 12 years and his vision for a Viksit Bharat, PM Modi invoking his lifelong mission to serve the nation, said he was committed to make India a developed nation.

"From 74 airports in 2014 to over 160 airports by 2026; from 1,000 kilometres of expressways in 2014 to 6,700 kilometres by 2026; from metro services in just five cities in 2014 to over twenty cities by 2026; and from Rs 700 crore in defence exports in 2014 to Rs 23,000 crore by 2026, the country has traversed a long journey. In 2014, there were only 25 crore internet users in the country; today, over 100 crore users are connected to the internet. In 2014, digital payments were negligible; today, India ranks number one in digital transactions," he said.

"The point is, if so much could be achieved in 12 years, why didn't it happen over the preceding decades? This illustrates the difference between the Congress-era growth rate and the NDA-era growth rate. One system kept people waiting; today's system delivers results. One system used to stall and derail work; today's system ensures that work gets done on time and on a massive scale. The story from 2014 to 2026 is not merely a tale of statistics. It is the story of an India that has, for the first time, begun to run at its full potential, an India

that sets ambitious goals and works tirelessly to achieve them," PM Modi said.

Government marks 12 years with Nation First...

Over 36,000 defence products were identified for large-scale manufacture in India, and manufacturing of more than 12,000 products has already begun, it said.

As part of Operation Sindoor, it added, nine terror hideouts were destroyed.

Operation Sindoor was launched on May 7, 2025, to avenge the deadly Pahalgam terror attack on April 22 last year. Under the military response, Indian forces conducted precision strikes on multiple terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-Occupied-Kashmir.

The military conflict between the two nuclear-armed neighbours, lasting nearly 88 hours, came to a halt after they reached an understanding on the evening of May 10.

Adhikari keeps the reins, hands key roles to...

Gouri Shankar Ghosh, considered close to Adhikari, was given charge of tourism and parliamentary affairs and the backward classes welfare department, while Noapara MLA Arjun Singh was assigned labour and transport. Letician was given information technology and electronics, as well as science and technology, biotechnology, food processing, and horticulture. Manoj Kumar Oraon, a BJP leader from North Bengal, was made forest minister. Arup Kumar Das was given the irrigation and waterways department, while Ajay Poddar will handle public health engineering.

Among the ministers of state with independent charge, Indranil Khan will oversee sports and youth affairs, as well as consumer affairs. Malati Rava Roy will handle women and child development, self-help groups, and project monitoring. Rajesh Mahata, a Kudmi leader from Jhargram, was made minister of state with independent charge for animal resources development and fisheries.

India Protests Tanker Attack, Summons US...

While search efforts continue for those reported missing, India is closely monitoring the situation through its diplomatic missions and maritime agencies. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) has expressed deep concern over the incident, emphasising that attacks on commercial shipping threaten regional stability and endanger civilian seafarers.

New Delhi has called for strict adherence to international maritime norms and the protection of freedom of navigation in international waters. The latest episode comes amid heightened tensions in West Asia and increased enforcement actions

against vessels suspected of violating sanctions-related restrictions. Several recent incidents involving merchant shipping in the Gulf region have raised concerns among maritime operators and governments alike. Reports of missile attacks on commercial vessels carrying Indian crew members have prompted India to intensify diplomatic engagement with regional stakeholders and major powers.

Officials said India's immediate priority remains the safety and welfare of its seafarers. The government is coordinating with Omani authorities and international maritime agencies to ascertain the circumstances surrounding the attack and secure the safe return of all Indian nationals affected by the incident.

Tensions surge in West Asia as US, Iran...

President Trump reiterated that Iran would face consequences for delaying negotiations, signalling a significant shift in tone from earlier comments supporting a negotiated settlement.

Meanwhile, a source familiar with the talks told US based media that a Qatari delegation is currently meeting Iranian negotiators in Tehran in an attempt to bridge remaining differences and revive momentum toward a potential agreement between the two countries.

Iran stated that it launched retaliatory strikes against American military bases in Jordan and Kuwait after the US military reported carrying out strikes inside Iran following the downing of a US Army helicopter.

In Bahrain, footage reviewed and geolocated by the authorities appears to show a flash of light near a US military installation, though officials have not yet confirmed the nature of the incident. Within Iran, explosions were reported at three strategic locations around the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most critical energy transit routes. Iranian state media reported that two water reservoirs were struck during the attacks, resulting in disruptions to local water supplies.

The latest cycle of attacks has prompted warnings from governments and security experts worldwide. Analysts caution that what has so far been described as a "controlled escalation" carries a growing risk of miscalculation, potentially triggering a wider conflict in an already volatile region.

As military operations continue and diplomatic efforts struggle to gain traction, the situation remains highly fluid, with significant implications for regional stability and global energy markets.

CBI arrests Delhi cop in `3-crore bribery case

The charges pertain to the demand and acceptance of illegal gratification to secure undue favour in the CBI investigation. Singh allegedly used his position and connections to offer to derail or dilute the case.

Inspector Singh allegedly used his position and connections to offer to derail or dilute the case. During a meeting arranged by the middleman, a senior public servant, understood to be a regional director of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), promised the businessman "favourable investigation" in exchange for the bribe, with ₹1.5 crore demanded upfront. This made the DGCA official's alleged role central to the probe, and part of the amount was allegedly routed through hawala channels, officials said.

"The arrested persons were caught red-handed while accepting the first instalment of the bribe. Further investigations are on to uncover the full conspiracy and identify other beneficiaries, including the senior public servant whose role is under active scanner in the case," a CBI spokesperson said.

The case has sent ripples through both the Delhi Police and civil aviation circles, with senior officials confirming that the probe will be taken to its logical conclusion irrespective of the ranks involved. Singh and Rajkumar have been produced before a special CBI court and remanded in judicial custody. The agency is expected to file a chargesheet within the stipulated period after completing searches and recording witnesses' statements. This is the second arrest of a Delhi Police Inspector by the CBI in quick succession. Earlier, the CBI had arrested Inspector Subhash Yadav, posted with the Anti-Narcotics cell of Dwarka district, for demanding and accepting a bribe. Inspector Yadav is accused of running an organised extortion racket. The CBI probe has uncovered large sums of cash, hidden assets, and a ₹100-crore money trail, far more than an inspector could earn.

From underworld routes to Instagram...

His target, they say, is to radicalise vulnerable Indian youth, poor, jobless, and gullible, via Instagram, WhatsApp, and YouTube.

Bhatti offers cash, visas and investigators say, draws them into reconnaissance, grenade attacks, and assassinations. After strikes, recruits are ordered to scrawl "TTH" (his fake "Tehreek-e-Taliban Hindustan" front) and 'S' for Shahzad on walls to claim the attacks. Bhatti has also boasted online, they say, about incidents like hurling a grenade at Jallandhar-based influencer Roger Sandhu's house and the Punjab cop killings. Sources in Indian security agencies say the Jhingada-Bhatti axis is a highly dangerous synergy. Jhingada supplies the guns, cash, and street muscle, while Bhatti delivers the recruits and propaganda. Together, they are described as ISI's cheaper, deniable upgrade on old terror outfits like LeT and JeM, blending 1990s underworld logistics with 2020s influencer warfare. According to investigators, ISI had planned to target Delhi temples, Hisar army camps, Delhi-Sonipat dhabas, police stations, and crowded markets. Their goal was mass bloodshed and communal riots aimed at eroding faith in security forces.

Delhi Police's 17-day operation in May 2026 put

the brakes on this network. Across three states, eight suspects were arrested, including UP's Vijay 'Shooter, Jharkhand's Nitish Paswan, and Punjab youths. Investigators say Nepali Lama, the ninth, exposed Jhingada's direct pipeline. Seizures included four Pakistan-made hand grenades, two Glock 19s with 24 rounds, stolen vehicles, and videos that allegedly scouted hospitals, political offices, and paramilitary bases. Intense crackdowns in UP, Punjab, and Haryana led to the tracking of over 500 suspicious social media handles and numbers.

Security agencies describe it as Pakistan's full-spectrum hybrid assault, exploiting every Indian fault line while hiding behind deniability. ISI, officials say, pumps narcotics and arms to fund the slaughter, radicalises the line, and reactivates D-Company ghosts to keep India bleeding without triggering all-out retaliation.

Bhatti moves freely from Pakistan, spewing threats at Indian leaders and celebs while his network floods the country with death. India is hitting back hard. Coordinated raids, digital hunts, and de-radicalisation are dismantling modules nationwide. But the Jhingada-Bhatti hydra proves one ugly truth: as long as Pakistan shelters these terrorists, new heads will keep sprouting.

Fresh jolt for TMC, Sushmita Dev quits

Dev did not comment on TMC chief Mamata Banerjee or her plans. She said, "It's my individual decision, what kind of politics I want to do and who should be my leader. I have my reasons, and that's why I have made my decision." Regarding reports that she was joining the BJP, she said, "When I make a decision, I will let you know." Dev said she had resigned due to personal and political reasons and that "everyone has the right to change their mind, and to decide what kind of politics they want to do."

She is the daughter of former Union minister and Congress leader Santosh Mohan Dev. She previously served as an MP from Silchar in Assam and was also president of the All India Mahila Congress. Earlier in the day, Dev met the Rajya Sabha chairman and handed over her resignation letter.

"I convey my sincere gratitude to your excellency, hon'ble deputy chairman and all functionaries of the Rajya Sabha secretariat extending all help and cooperation during my tenure as a member of the Rajya Sabha," Dev said in the letter to the Chairman.

Dev is the second Trinamool Congress MP from the Rajya Sabha to resign this week. Another TMC leader, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, also left the party and gave up his seat in the Council of States.

Sources said several party MPs are considering forming a separate group and joining the ruling NDA. This is similar to what seven AAP MPs did when they left the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and later joined the BJP.

Most of Trinamool's 80 MLAs have already formed a separate group. Ritabrata Banerjee is now the leader of the opposition in the state Assembly.

President Murmu hails Modi on becoming longest-serving PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE/PTI
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu has congratulated Prime Minister Narendra Modi on marking the milestone of serving as India's longest continuously elected PM and said that during this period, the country has witnessed significant transformations across all facets of national life.

In a letter to the PM, Murmu said that, be it the welfare of the poor, healthcare for all, empowering farmers, protecting the interests of the middle and neo-middle classes, "your all-inclusive vision and actions have transformed millions of lives."

"I was deeply touched by your compassion for the marginalised sections of our society and your commitment to the ideal of *Antyodaya* — upliftment of the person at the very end of the line. It reflected not merely a policy intervention, but a profound sensitivity towards some of the most vulnerable citizens of Bharat," Murmu said.

The President said that the regions that had long remained outside the principal arc of India's development story have received special attention and care under Modi's leadership.

This is especially true about the eastern and north-eastern parts of India, which had lagged behind in terms of development indicators, she said.

Such efforts reflect the spirit of people-centric and people-powered governance, which seeks to ensure that the fruits of develop-



ment reach the last person and that no region, community or citizen is left behind, Murmu said.

"Your own journey from humble beginnings to becoming India's longest-serving elected Prime Minister, continuously serving the people, also reaffirms one of the most inspiring features of Indian democracy. It demonstrates that in our Republic, public life remains open to all those who dedicate themselves to service, commitment and hard work for the betterment of the nation," she said in a letter dated June 9.

"You have led the country with the spirit of Nation First and have achieved the unique blend of tradition and development. Now India occupies its rightful place of importance in the global community," read Murmu's letter to Modi.

Asserting that history records the years spent in office, the president said that the people remember how those years touched their lives, expanded their opportunities and strengthened their faith in the future.

"The true measure of public service ultimately resides in the lives transformed, and the hopes realised. I am confident that your unwavering commitment to the ideals of service and seva, inclusion and national development will steer India towards the fulfilment of its aspirations," Murmu said.

Describing Prime Minister Modi as a leader who has rekindled confidence in the nation's capabilities and aspirations through visionary leadership, tireless service, and unwavering commitment to the ideal of "*Rashtra Pratham*", Vice President CP Radhakrishnan said he has emerged as a true "Yug Purush" of contemporary Bharat.

Extending congratulations to the Prime Minister, Radhakrishnan, in a social media message, described Modi's continuous tenure as a historic milestone that reflects a transformative era in Bharat's development journey under the Prime Minister's visionary leadership.

He noted that Bharat has

witnessed remarkable progress across every sphere, including economic growth, infrastructure expansion, social empowerment and technological advancement. He further observed that India's enhanced global stature and renewed civilizational confidence have emerged as defining features of this period.

Highlighting the Prime Minister's commitment to inclusive development, the Vice President stated that more than 25 crore people have been lifted out of absolute poverty, bringing hope, opportunity and dignity to millions of families.

The Vice-President also lauded the Prime Minister's efforts to preserve and promote Bharat's rich cultural and civilizational heritage.

Referring to Prime Minister Modi's invocation of the Tamil phrase "*Yaadhum Oore, Yaavarum Kelir*" ("Every place is our home; everyone is our kin") at the United Nations, Radhakrishnan said it eloquently reaffirmed Bharat's timeless ethos of "*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*" and its enduring message of universal brotherhood and human unity.

The Vice-President further highlighted several initiatives undertaken by the Prime Minister to reinforce India's civilizational unity and cultural legacy, including the Kashi Tamil Sangamam, Saurashtra Tamil Sangamam, installation of the sacred Sengol in the new Parliament building, his visit to Gangaikonda Cholapuram to honour the legacy of the Cholas, and the repatriation of invaluable artefacts and antiquities from abroad.

PM Modi presiding over murder of democracy: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday criticised Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying he may have passed a "self-proclaimed and dubiously invented" milestone, but he is a "millstone" around India's neck, presiding over the "murder of democracy". The Opposition party's attack came as Modi became India's longest continuously serving elected prime minister.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said Jawaharlal Nehru became prime minister of India on August 15, 1947, presiding over a stellar Cabinet — the likes of which have rarely been seen in the world. Over the next five years, modern India came into being, he said on social media.

"Over 560 princely states were integrated peacefully into the Indian Union, the Constitution of India was debated and adopted, zamindari was abolished, reservations for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes were put in place, a number of multipurpose irrigation-cum-power projects were launched, the infrastructure for science and technol-

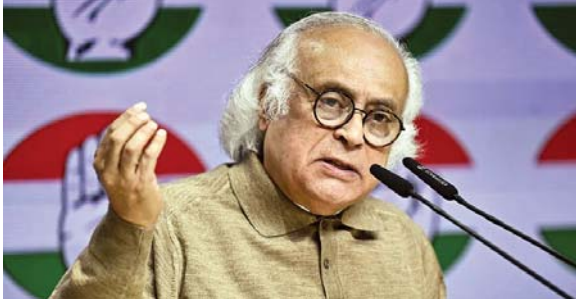
ogy capability was established (including in nuclear energy), and India emerged as a force in global affairs," Ramesh said.

Electoral rolls bearing 170 million registered voters were prepared to ensure universal adult franchise, and India's first General Elections were held between October 1951 and February 1952, he said.

"The 1947-52 record of achievements of India with Nehru as PM, in which stalwarts like Sardar Patel, Dr Ambedkar, Dr Rajendra Prasad, C Rajagopalachari, and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad played such a pivotal role, is now sought to be erased by Mr Modi, who has a pathological fixation on Nehru," the Congress general secretary in-charge communications alleged.

"He (Modi) may have passed a self-proclaimed and dubiously invented milestone today, but he is a millstone around India's neck, presiding as he is over the Murder of Democracy in India," Ramesh alleged.

The very same establishments of democracy — an independent Election Commission and a sacrosanct voter list — are now threatened, he claimed.



Income tax burden reduction reflects *Ramrajya*: Union Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The reduction in income tax burden over the past 12 years reflects the Government's vision of "*Ramrajya*", said a booklet released by the Government to mark Narendra Modi's tenure as India's longest-serving Prime Minister.

Reforms like GST, faceless tax, and Digital India have helped build 12 years of trust in the public system, which will support India in becoming a \$5-trillion economy, the booklet, released on Wednesday, said.

Highlighting the achievements of the Modi Government, it said that increased taxpayer confidence has enabled greater investment in roads, hospitals, infrastructure, and other initiatives aimed at strengthening the country's future.



The Modi Government has provided tax relief to people on four occasions since 2014. Annual tax-free income limit has been hiked 6 times in the last 12 years — from ₹2 lakh to ₹12.75 lakh now. The income taxpayer base rose sharply to 12.13 crore from 5.26 crore during the period.

"When the Government's income increased, that money did not stay in the treasury; it returned to the

citizens," the booklet said. Also, quicker income tax refunds have improved cash availability for taxpayers.

"The tax burden has decreased, and people's trust has increased. The result is that the number of taxpayers keeps growing because people see their money going into roads, hospitals, and the future of the country. This is what good governance is, this is the message of '*Ramrajya*,'" it added.

Chenab bridge, Vande Bharat among 12-year rail feats: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Construction of the world's highest railway arch bridge over the Chenab river, the launch of the first Vande Bharat Sleeper train, and 99.6 per cent electrification of the broad-gauge network are among the major achievements highlighted by the Government during its 12 years in office.

A booklet released by the Government to mark the occasion lists several significant launches and developments in the field of rail infrastructure across the country.

Highlighting the 99.6 per cent electrification of the broad-gauge railway network, which makes India one of the most highly electrified railway systems in the world, the Government said this achievement is a cornerstone of the nation's sustainable transportation and

economic growth strategy.

It said the initiative has helped reduce carbon emissions and strengthened the country's commitment to the Net Zero goal.

The booklet stated that 741 crore passengers were served by the railways in 2025-26 and that national capacity has been enhanced with the introduction of premium train services such as Vande Bharat, Nammo Bharat and Tejas.

The Government also said that obtaining tickets has become easier due to several initiatives undertaken by the Railway Ministry.

It said following the stellar debut of the Vande Bharat Sleeper train, over 1.2 lakh passengers travelled on the service in its first three months, recording 100 per cent occupancy.

Celebrating the construction and operationalisation of the world's highest railway arch bridge, standing 359 metres above the Chenab



River, the Government said the structure is a state-of-the-art engineering marvel showcasing India's technological prowess.

It noted that the bridge stands 35 metres taller than the Eiffel Tower.

The bridge, India's first blast-resistant railway bridge developed with assistance from DRDO, has facilitated direct rail connectivity between Jammu and Srinagar, reducing travel time significantly.

The Government also highlighted the Anji Khad Bridge,

constructed, compared with only 125 km built before 2014.

Providing a glimpse of India's first bullet train project, the Government said the 508-km Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail Project, currently under construction, spans Gujarat, Maharashtra and Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu. It added that foundation work has been completed at eight of the project's 12 stations.

The Government further said that all civil works, including river bridges, have been completed on the 97-km Surat-Vapi section, while nearly 5 km of the approximately 21-km undersea tunnel has also been completed.

Talking about the rapid resolution of railway complaints, it said, "Through the 139 Helpline, mobile applications and SMS services, the average grievance redressal time has been reduced to just 20-25 minutes."

Navy to get GNSS jammers in ₹449 cr deal: Defence ministry



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The defence ministry on Wednesday signed a ₹449-crore contract with a firm for the procurement of 20 enhanced capability Global Navigation Satellite System (ECGNSS) jammers for the Indian Navy, officials said.

The contract has been signed under the 'Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed, Developed and Manufactured)' category, the ministry said. The eventual induction of the jammers would pave the way for safe operations by the Navy's ships in a multi-threat environment, it added.

The ministry has signed a contract with Accord Software and Systems Private Limited (ASSPL), Bengaluru, for the "procurement of 20 Enhanced Capability Global Navigation Satellite System (ECGNSS) jammers for the Indian Navy at a total cost of ₹449 crore, with minimum 75 per cent indigenous content," it said.

It was inked in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in New Delhi.

"The system's capabilities include degrading the satellite signal acquisition and tracking performance of the adversary GNSS receiver and signal spoofing or deceptive jamming," the statement said.

Abhishek meets Rahul to strengthen coordination within INDIA bloc

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Trinamool Congress national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee met Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi for an hour and a half on Wednesday. The closed-door discussion at 10 Janpath comes amid ongoing efforts by opposition parties to improve coordination and present a more cohesive front against the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) Government.



According to sources familiar with the deliberations, the Trinamool Congress conveyed its desire for a robust and effective alliance within the INDIA grouping. The party is understood to have explicitly accepted Rahul Gandhi's leadership role in steering the Opposition bloc. This stance reflects the Trinamool's willingness to work closely with other constituents to strengthen the platform formed ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. The Congress, on its part, main-

tained a measured position during the meeting, saying it is not actively pushing for any organisational merger with the Trinamool Congress.

Any proposal for such a merger, the Congress has emphasised, would need to originate from the Trinamool side itself. This clarification appears aimed at dispelling speculation about immediate moves towards a formal amalgamation of the two parties, while keeping the door open for enhanced political cooperation at the

national level.

The INDIA bloc includes major regional players such as the Trinamool Congress, the Samajwadi Party, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and others. It was conceived as a broad-based platform to challenge the dominance of the Bharatiya Janata Party-led NDA. However, differences over seat-sharing arrangements, leadership projections and regional priorities have occasionally tested the alliance's cohesion since its inception.

CRPF DG orders round-the-clock vigil along Amarnath Yatra route

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

The Director General of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has directed the field commanders to scale up counter-terror operations on higher ridges while maintaining strict, round-the-clock vigil along the Amarnath yatra route to ensure peaceful conduct of the annual pilgrimage beginning July 3.

These directions were passed by the DG CRPF GP Singh while chairing a high-level security review meeting

in Srinagar during his three-day visit to the valley.

According to a post on X by CRPF India, DG CRPF, GP Singh, chaired a high-level meeting with the senior officials and commanders of CRPF in Srinagar.

During the meeting, DG CRPF directed the commanders to scale up counter-terror operations on higher ridges while maintaining strict, round-the-clock vigil across the plains.

According to official sources, the central paramilitary forces dispatched for

the yatra duty have started taking charge of their areas of operation to ensure incident-free conduct of the yatra.

According to a post by CRPF India on X, DG CRPF stressed on enhancing security grids to maintain peace & normalcy for a safe and incident-free Shri Amarnath ji Yatra 2026.

Meanwhile, as the situation remains highly volatile in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), Chief of Army Staff (COAS) General Upendra Dwivedi visited the Northern Command head-



quarters in Udhampur district on Tuesday and reviewed its operational

preparedness, capability development, and ongoing modernisation initiatives.

"General Upendra Dwivedi, COAS, visited Northern Command and reviewed its operational preparedness, capability development and modernisation initiatives," the Army's Additional Directorate General of Public Information (ADGPI) said on X. During the visit on Tuesday, the army chief was briefed on the conduct of multi-domain operations, technology absorption, infrastructure development and integrated combat readiness across the full spectrum of military operations, officials said.



States Focus



FADNAVIS DEFENDS MINISTER AMID OP BLUE STAR ROW

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Wednesday defended state minister Girish Mahajan amid a controversy over his "Operation Blue Star was a black day remark, saying his remarks should be seen in entirety in the context of the "Congress-led" 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

Mahajan sparked a political storm by calling Operation Blue Star a "black day" and equating the 1984 Army action to an invasion by Afghan ruler Ahmad Shah Abdali, with Opposition parties raising demand for his sacking.

The Opposition accused Mahajan of "glorifying" militants and insulting the armed forces.

"The massacre of Sikhs in Delhi, Punjab and across India under the leadership of the Congress party is a historical fact. Nobody can forget this truth," Fadnavis told reporters in New Delhi. Referring to criticism of Mahajan's speech, Fadnavis said, "If you look at Mahajan's entire statement, such a question won't arise. Girish Mahajan has already clarified." (PTI)



CHENAB HYDRO PROJECT MAY DIVERT 197 HECTARES OF LAND

Chenab Valley Power Projects has sought diversion of about 197 hectares of forest land for the construction of the Kirthai Stage-II Hydroelectric Project on the Chenab river in Kishtwar district. Kirthai II is part of several other hydroelectric projects in the Indus basin that the Centre has sought to expedite after putting the Indus Waters Treaty with Pakistan on hold last year. Under the now-suspended treaty, Pakistan controlled the waters of the Indus, Jhelum and Chenab rivers, while India controlled the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. The environment ministry's Forest Advisory Committee, which grants approval for diversion, appraised the hydroelectric project on Wednesday. (PTI)

Maharashtra: Bomb threat emails target RSS HQ, CM office



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai/Nagpur/Pune

Civic authorities in Maharashtra on Wednesday received bomb threat emails targeting the RSS headquarters in Nagpur, the Chief Minister's Office, and the mayoral offices in Mumbai and Pune, prompting evacuations at some places and security searches, officials said.

Police went into a tizzy after Nagpur Mayor Neeta Thakre received an email claiming an explosive device was planted at the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) headquarters in Mahal area, Dr Hedgewar Smruti Bhavan in Reshimbagh.

Following the threat, a Bomb Detection and Disposal Squad (BDDS) was immediately rushed to the spot for a thorough search, the officials said, adding that nothing suspicious was found.

Security checks were intensified, and all sensitive areas were being inspected as a precautionary measure.

The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) received emails "warning" of explosions at multiple locations in the State Capital, including the mayor's office and the Chief Minister's Office, officials said.

The emails, sent to many official email IDs of the civic corporation, prompted security agencies to launch an investigation, they said.

According to officials, the emails warned of bomb blasts at the mayor's office, CMO, the BSE building and civic offices.

Congress in West Bengal split over possible tie-up with TMC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Even as the Congress high command held back-to-back meetings with Mamata Banerjee in New Delhi, growing speculation over a possible rapprochement or even a merger between the grand old party and the TMC has exposed fault lines within the Congress' West Bengal unit.

While senior Congress leaders in Delhi remained tight-lipped about the discussions, the possibility of accommodating Mamata Banerjee amid an internal crisis in the TMC has triggered sharply divergent reactions within the grand old party's State leadership.

At the centre of the debate is a politically sensitive question: if the Congress leader-



ship moves closer to Mamata Banerjee, will Bengal Congress workers — many of whom have spent years opposing the TMC — accept her as one of their own?

The question gained urgency after Mamata Banerjee met Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi on Tuesday, followed by a meeting between Abhishek

behind Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar. Sources in both parties acknowledged that discussions on the future of anti-BJP politics in Bengal and the changing political situation in the State figured in the conversations, though neither side officially confirmed reports of merger talks. Within the Bengal Congress, however, resistance is already visible.

A section of State leaders believes that embracing Mamata Banerjee now would burden the Congress with the political baggage of 15 years of alleged corruption, misgovernance and organisational erosion under TMC rule. Veteran Congress leaders Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury and Abdul Mannan have emerged as the most vocal opponents of any such move.

Banerjee and Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday.

The two rounds of talks fuelled intense political speculation, particularly against the backdrop of the unprecedented split within the TMC that saw a majority of its MLAs rally behind the rebel camp led by Leader of Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee and a large section of its Lok Sabha MPs rally

Dissidents are real TMC, rules out Congress merger: Ritabrata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

As Mamata Banerjee's meetings with the Congress leadership fuelled fresh speculation about the future of her embattled faction, rebel leader Ritabrata Banerjee on Wednesday claimed ownership of the Trinamool Congress itself, declaring that the dissident camp was the "real TMC" and had no plans to merge with the grand old party.

Claiming that the strength of the dissident bloc had risen from 58 to 64 MLAs, Ritabrata said the rebels enjoyed the support of a majority of the party's legislators and a growing number of MPs, and would continue to function under the Trinamool Congress banner. "We are the real Trinamool Congress. We are not merging with the Congress," Ritabrata told reporters outside the state

assembly. His remarks came amid heightened political speculation following Mamata Banerjee's meeting with Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi and reports of consultations between Abhishek Banerjee and senior Congress leaders in the national capital.

The meetings have fuelled intense chatter in political circles over the future course of the diminished Mamata-led faction of the TMC at a time when the party is battling the biggest internal crisis in its 28-year history.

Ritabrata, however, dismissed suggestions that the organisation could become part of any Congress-led arrangement. "The number of MLAs with us has already crossed 64. It may become 65 tomorrow when another MLA joins us. Naturally, we are the real Trinamool Congress. Who meets whom in Delhi is their



matter and is immaterial for us," he said. The rebel leader said a fresh communication reflecting the changed strength of the legislative bloc would be submitted to the Speaker. He further claimed that the dissident camp commanded support not only among MLAs but also among MPs, local body representatives and district-level leaders.

"Most legislators are not

ment assumes significance as 20 rebel TMC MPs have already informed Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla about the formation of a separate parliamentary bloc under the leadership of Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar and pledged support to the NDA.

The TMC's organisational crisis burst into the open earlier this week when a rebellion that had first fractured its ranks in the West Bengal Assembly spread to Parliament.

The parliamentary rupture came days after 58 TMC MLAs, a figure the rebel camp now claims has climbed to 64, defied the party leadership and backed expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee as Leader of the Opposition instead of the party's official nominee, Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay.

The twin rebellions have plunged Mamata Banerjee's party into arguably the gravest crisis since its formation in

1998, transforming what began as internal dissent into a battle over legislative strength, parliamentary numbers, organisational control and political legitimacy.

The split has steadily widened from the Assembly to Parliament, with senior Rajya Sabha members Sukhendu Sekhar Ray and Sushmita Dev resigning from both the Upper House and the party. Against this backdrop, the Delhi meetings between Mamata Banerjee, Abhishek Banerjee and the Congress leadership have acquired added political significance, with speculation rife that sections of the TMC still loyal to the Banerjees could explore closer ties or a merger with the Congress.

Though neither side has publicly spoken of a merger, the meetings have generated enough political buzz for the rebel camp to repeatedly clarify its position.

BJP alleges ₹39,000-crore waste management scam in Bengaluru

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Leader of the Opposition R Ashoka on Wednesday alleged that the Congress Government had engineered a ₹39,000-crore scam in Bengaluru's waste management and received a ₹10,000-crore kickback through a long-term garbage processing tender awarded to a private company.

The BJP leader, who later submitted a complaint to Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot seeking an investigation into the tender



Leader of the Opposition R Ashoka

process, claimed the contract had been awarded to a single company for 35 years at highly inflated rates, causing a massive

financial burden on the public exchequer.

"This is the first time in the country's history that such a massive loot of

₹35,000 crore has taken place in the name of garbage. This is a 'high-command black-money tender'," Ashoka told reporters at a press conference. He also released documents to back his allegation. Ashoka alleged that the tender for waste processing and disposal had been awarded to Delhi-based MSW Solutions Ltd, or its parent company Ramky, for 30 years with a provision for a five-year extension, taking the total contract period to 35 years. Ashoka said Bengaluru currently

spends ₹514 crore annually on garbage collection and transportation, Rs 380 crore on processing and disposal, and ₹444 crore towards salaries of 11,000 civic workers, taking the total annual expenditure to ₹1,344 crore.

He alleged that despite local contractors handling waste management work in the Greater Bengaluru Area (GBA) so far, the new ₹39,000-crore tender had been awarded to a Delhi-based company and involved a Rs 10,000-crore kickback. According to him, Bengaluru

had been divided into North and South packages and recommendations provided by the Government-owned RITES had been ignored.

Instead, he alleged, an unaccredited consultant had been engaged and the selected company had also been allowed to raise loans of up to ₹1,500 crore with Government land support. Claiming that the financial burden had been inflated drastically, Ashoka said the tipping fee, currently ₹260 per tonne, had been increased to ₹2,400 per tonne under the new tender.

IIT Bhubaneswar develops device for arsenic detection in water

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Researchers at IIT Bhubaneswar have developed a portable device for rapid detection of arsenic in drinking water, offering a low-cost and field-deployable solution to address a major public health concern, officials said on Wednesday.

The research was carried out by a team from the Sensors and Spectroscopy Research Group of the School of Electrical and



Computer Sciences (SECS), led by Sayan Dey, focusing on affordable, sensitive and field-deployable technologies for arsenic detection.

According to a statement by the institute, the team

developed a compact handheld arsenic detection device, named 'ArsenSafe', through a startup incubated at the Research and Entrepreneurship Park of IIT Bhubaneswar.

Designed for rapid, cost-effective and on-site testing, the device enables accurate detection of arsenic contamination without the need for laboratory infrastructure or chemical reagents, making water-quality assessment faster and more accessible, it said.

6 dead bodies found in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Imphal

The Manipur Police on Wednesday said they found the mortal remains of six people, suspected to be of missing Naga men, who had been held hostage by armed groups in Kangpokpi district.

The recovery took place a day after 14 Kuki individuals who were abducted by armed groups in Manipur's Senapati district nearly a month ago were released. Welcoming this development, the chief ministers of Nagaland and Meghalaya had sought the safe release of the six Naga hostages.

"After nearly 24 hours of sustained search operations involving around 450 personnel of the Manipur Police, CRPF, and Assam Rifles, assisted by sniffer dogs and forensic expert teams, the mortal remains of six persons



were recovered this afternoon. The deceased are believed to be among those taken hostage from Leilon Vaiphei on May 13, 2026," the police said in an X post.

These 14 Kuki people and the six Nagas were among others who were abducted following the killing of three church leaders in Kangpokpi district on May 13.

16 crore rural households now have tap water connections: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday became India's longest continuously serving prime minister and completed 12 years in office, a Government document released to mark the occasion said nearly 16 crore rural households now have tap water connections under the Jal Jeevan Mission, taking safe drinking water coverage to over 81 per cent.

Launched on August 15, 2019, the Jal Jeevan Mission aims to provide tap water to every rural household in the country. At the time of



its launch, only 3.23 crore rural households, or 16.71 per cent of the total, had access to tap water connections. Since then, over 12.5 crore additional households have been connected, taking the total coverage to nearly 16 crore households.

Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil congratulated Modi and called the milestone a testament to public trust and dedicated national service.

In a post on X, Patil said Modi has completed 4,399 days in office in an uninterrupted journey devoted to serving the nation.

"As a leader who trans-

formed public aspirations into resolutions and resolutions into achievements, Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji has given a new momentum and new direction to India's development journey," he said.

"Inspired by the spirit of Antyodaya, Modi's efforts to ensure that the benefits of development reach the last person in society, promote India's cultural consciousness globally and build a self-reliant and developed India have become an important chapter in the country's progress, Patil said.

He said Modi's achievement of becoming India's

longest continuously serving elected prime minister symbolises the strength of democracy, the steadfastness of public trust and the collective resolve for a brighter future.

"This journey of dedication to service, good governance, and national interest continues unabated," Patil added.

Modi first assumed office on May 26, 2014. He completed an uninterrupted tenure of 4,399 days on Wednesday, surpassing the record of India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, who served continuously for 4,398 days.

ED attaches house worth ₹60 crore in S Kumars case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A sea-facing house worth ₹60 crore in Maharashtra's Murud town has been attached by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in a bank loan fraud-linked money-laundering case against textile major S Kumars Nationwide Limited (SKNL) and its former CMD, Nitin Kasliwal.

The federal agency said in a statement on Wednesday that a provisional order has been issued under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) to attach the house, which commands a market value of more than ₹60 crore.

The "diverted" funds from SKNL were utilised for the acquisition of the Arabian Sea-facing immovable property near Alibaug in Murud town of Maharashtra's Raigad district. The immovable asset was found to be derived directly from the "proceeds of crime" of the ₹1,400-crore SKNL "bank fraud", the ED claimed.

Kasliwal is accused of defrauding a consortium of Indian banks to the tune of ₹1,400 crore, according to the agency.

The ED, in December last year, attached an immovable asset worth ₹119.55 crore located near London's Buckingham Palace as part of its investigation.

The agency has alleged that Kasliwal, the former chairman and managing director of SKNL, utilised a network of interconnected entities and controlled by him and his family members for diverting and layering funds during the period when the company availed substantial credit facilities .

Himanta praises PM Modi for putting Assam on growth path

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday conveyed his greetings and best wishes to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the latter becoming India's longest-serving Prime Minister. Meeting Modi during the celebrations marking the 12th anniversary of the NDA Government at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, Sarma handed over a heartfelt letter expressing the gratitude, affection and admiration of Assam's 3.5 crore people.

In the letter, the Chief Minister described Modi's tenure as a transformative period that reshaped Assam's relationship with the Centre and accelerated the State's development trajectory, helping it evolve from being perceived as a dependent State to becoming a significant contributor to India's growth story.

In the letter, Sarma said



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma with BJP leader Tarun Chugh before a meeting of the ruling National Democratic Alliance leaders to celebrate its government completing 12 years in New Delhi

that for decades, people in Assam and the North East often felt distant from the national mainstream despite being proud Indians. He noted that under Modi's leadership, the region was brought from the periphery to the centre of national priorities, transforming the relationship between Assam and New Delhi. The Chief Minister

highlighted Modi's vision for the North East, particularly his description of the region as 'Ashtalakshmi' and his assertion that the North East would become the 'New Engine' of India's growth. According to Sarma, these ideas instilled confidence in millions and helped redefine the region's identity from one associated with chal-

lenges to one recognised for its strengths and potential.

He also recalled Modi's appreciation of Assam when the State became the first in India to ratify the GST, noting that the Prime Minister's spontaneous remark, 'A for Assam,' resonated deeply with the people.

Sarma emphasised Modi's unique bond with Assam,

pointing out that he has visited the State 36 times during his tenure as Prime Minister — more than any of his predecessors. He said each visit reinforced the message that Assam's future and aspirations mattered to the nation.

The letter also highlighted Modi's consistent promotion of Assamese identity, particularly through his frequent use of the traditional phulam gamocha on national and international platforms.

Sarma further recalled moments that showcased the Prime Minister's humility, including an interaction with tea garden communities during the distribution of land pattas, when Modi gently stopped a beneficiary from touching his feet and instead bent down himself, a gesture the Chief Minister said reflected his deep respect for the dignity of every citizen.

The Chief Minister credited

Modi with giving unprecedented national and global visibility to Assam's rich cultural traditions. He cited the historic Bihu performance involving thousands of artists, recognition of the Bodo community's Bagurumba dance, and the celebration of Jhumur culture as moments that instilled pride among various communities across the State.

According to Sarma, these initiatives elevated Assam's cultural heritage from a regional legacy to a national treasure. He also recalled Modi's visit to Kaziranga, where he became the first Prime Minister to spend a night at the world-famous national park, bringing global attention to one of Assam's most cherished natural treasures.

The letter highlighted several milestones achieved during Modi's tenure, including the inscription of Charaideo Moidam as a

UNESCO World Heritage Site, the conferment of Classical Language status on Assamese, and renewed national recognition of Ahom general Lachit Barphukan, including the unveiling of his 125-foot statue.

According to Sarma, these achievements strengthened Assam's cultural identity and secured long-awaited recognition for its historical contributions.

Highlighting economic progress, the Chief Minister pointed to major investments such as the expansion of Numaligarh Refinery to 9 MMTPA, the bamboo-based Bio-Refinery project and the Rs 27,000-crore Tata semiconductor facility at Jagiroad. He described the semiconductor project as a landmark achievement that signalled Assam's emergence in advanced technology and manufacturing.

Sarma also cited the transformation of infrastructure

under Modi's leadership, including the new terminal at Lokapriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport and the rapid expansion of connectivity across the Brahmaputra through completed bridges, projects under construction, new corridors and the proposed underwater tunnel, which together promise to dramatically improve connectivity and economic integration across the State.

Concluding the letter, Sarma said the people of Assam view these developments not merely as policy achievements but as evidence of a leadership that recognised, respected and invested in the aspirations of the state. He conveyed the collective gratitude of the people of Assam to Prime Minister Modi, stating that his leadership had fundamentally altered Assam's development trajectory and strengthened its place in India's future.

Natarajan's Rajya Sabha nomination rejection a conspiracy: Siddaramaiah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Wednesday targeted Prime Minister Narendra Modi, claiming that the election machinery under his watch had "illegally" rejected the nomination of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan for the Rajya Sabha election from Madhya Pradesh.

Alleging that the BJP used the election machinery to reject the Congress candidate's nomination, he said it was "peak irony" that this happened on the day the BJP was celebrating Modi's "supposed long stay in power as a cooked-up milestone for Indian democracy."

The upcoming elections to three Rajya Sabha seats in Madhya Pradesh took a dramatic turn in Bhopal on Tuesday after Natarajan's nomination was rejected on charges of concealing information about a case in her affidavit.

"It is peak irony that, on the day the BJP is celebrating PM Modi's supposed long stay in power as a cooked-up mile-



stone for Indian democracy, the election machinery under his watch has illegally rejected the nomination of Congress candidate Meenakshi Natarajan for the Rajya Sabha election from Madhya Pradesh," Siddaramaiah said.

"This is the real condition of democracy under Modi. The rejection of Natarajan's nomination is not a routine scrutiny decision. It is a blatant illegality and a clear political conspiracy," the Congress Working Committee member posted on X. Noting that the BJP had the numbers to win only two Rajya Sabha seats from Madhya Pradesh, the former CM said the party had nevertheless fielded a third candi-

date and then attempted horse-trading by allegedly offering huge sums of money to Congress legislators.

"When those attempts started failing, and Congress MLAs stood united, the BJP used the election machinery to directly reject the Congress candidate's nomination," he alleged.

The grounds cited for rejecting her nomination were "completely illegal," he further claimed.

"There is no criminal case against Natarajan in the eyes of the law. A private complaint does not become a criminal case unless the court takes cognisance of it. A mere notice from a court is not a criminal case and need not be disclosed," he said.

Kerala CM says no decision yet on PM SHRI scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Wednesday said the State had not yet taken a decision on implementing the Centre's PM SHRI scheme and that a final call would be made only after examining the legal implications arising from an agreement signed by the previous LDF Government.

Responding to questions over media reports suggesting that the Congress-led UDF Government might join the scheme despite opposing it while in the Opposition, Satheesan said there were several issues, including PM SHRI and the Labour Code, on which the previous Government had already taken action. "We have not made any decision. Media reports are emerging based on decisions that have not been made. We will take a decision only after obtaining a legal opinion," he said.

The chief minister launched a sharp attack on the previous LDF Government, alleging that it had publicly opposed Kerala's participation in the Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India scheme while quietly signing an agreement with the Centre. According to Satheesan, the present situation arose because the previous Government entered into the MoU without informing even other members of the Cabinet.



"It was not individuals but the Government of Kerala that signed the agreement. Though Governments have changed, the State remains bound by agreements entered into in its name. We are examining the legal aspects of the matter," he said.

Satheesan alleged that only the then CM (Pinarayi Vijayan) and the then general education minister (V Sivankutty) were aware of the signing of the agreement.

He claimed that even while CPI ministers strongly opposed the scheme during Cabinet discussions, the fact that an MoU had already been signed was allegedly concealed from them.

Satheesan alleged that the agreement was signed without Cabinet approval and said the UDF's objec-

tion was primarily to the manner in which such an important decision was taken without informing coalition partners or the Cabinet.

His remarks came amid a political debate over the PM SHRI scheme, with sections of the media reporting that the UDF Government was considering joining the centrally sponsored programme.

The Opposition CPI(M) has accused the Government of attempting to implement the scheme despite its earlier criticism of it.

The PM SHRI issue became contentious during the tenure of the previous LDF Government after Kerala signed an MoU with the Centre.

The State later kept the scheme in abeyance following objections from coalition partner CPI, which argued that the programme could facilitate

the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.

Replying to questions on alleged saffronisation in university appointments and Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar's intervention in higher education matters, Satheesan said such interference in university affairs was not new and had occurred under previous Governments as well.

He said controversies relating to appointments to university syndicates and the selection of vice-chancellors were longstanding issues, adding that the responsibility for submitting the relevant panels rested with the previous Government. Satheesan said the governor's intervention in university affairs predated the present Government and added that the administration would undertake a comprehensive review of existing procedures related to universities.

Responding to criticism over the appointment of senior IAS officer B Ashok as Principal Secretary of the Higher Education Department, Satheesan said the Government did not take into account the political views or background of IAS officers while making appointments.

Ashok had publicly supported the governor's actions and was suspended earlier this year after disciplinary proceedings were initiated against him over alleged violations of service conduct rules.

Comparing Nehru and Modi illogical, says Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Shimla

All India Congress Committee spokesperson Kuldeep Singh Rathore on Wednesday ridiculed the BJP for comparing the tenures of Jawaharlal Nehru and Narendra Modi while celebrating the latter's 12 years in office, and said drawing parallels between the two prime ministers was illogical.

Addressing mediapersons in Shimla, Rathore said, "Instead of celebrating 12 years of Modi, the BJP should explain why his Government failed to resolve the issues of farmers, inflation and unemployment".

He remarked that what is important is not how long a prime minister remains in office but what he does for the development and pros-



perity of the nation and the strengthening of its democracy. Nehru relentlessly fought for the country's freedom, went to jail several times, and laid the foundation for a modern India by opening educational institutions, boosting science and technology, strengthening developmental infrastructure and launching five-year plans. Comparing Modi with him is neither logical nor judicious, the AICC spokesperson said.

All the former prime ministers significantly contributed to nation-building, but unemployment peaked during Modi's 12 years in power, he alleged, adding that "the youth is frustrated, the gap between rich and poor has widened, and policies are being framed to benefit big industrialists and not the common man".

Questioning the Government's foreign policy, he said global developments

indicate that India is not in a position of strength at the international level and "even our trusted allies are maintaining distance".

Pointing to the issues of Himachal Pradesh, Rathore said the Modi Government had promised to hike import duty on apples, but instead, the Free Trade Agreements it entered into significantly increased imports, affecting local growers. Referring to the recent paper leaks, Rathore demanded that Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradesh resign on moral grounds. He alleged that the Government is insensitive to the plight of the youth.

He added that he supported the statements of the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on the threat to democracy and India's critical financial situ-

Ex-West Bengal minister arrested in tarpaulin misappropriation case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Krishnanagar (WB)

Former West Bengal minister Ujjal Biswas has been arrested in connection with an alleged case of misappropriation of Government tarpaulins, police said.

The development took place on Tuesday night, hours after he was heckled by protesters outside his residence in Nadia district over the matter.

Biswas, the former correctional department minister and a senior TMC leader, was arrested following an investigation into a case registered at Kotwali police station, and he would be produced before a court on Wednesday, an



officer said. The arrest came after a day of high drama in Krishnanagar, where Biswas faced protests from local residents and BJP supporters over allegations that Government tarpaulins illegally stored at his residence were being shifted.

The controversy erupted in the afternoon when several tarpaulins were allegedly being loaded onto

a goods vehicle parked outside Biswas's house.

As the news spread, a crowd gathered outside the premises, accusing the former minister of illegally possessing Government relief materials. The protesters raised slogans and demanded immediate action against him.

The situation soon turned tense, with eggs reportedly being hurled at the former minister.

Biswas, however, dismissed the allegations and maintained that no misappropriation had taken place. As tension mounted, personnel from Kotwali police station reached the spot and escorted Biswas away from his residence.

Kerala to set up special force to tackle wild elephant attacks



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

The Kerala Government on Wednesday decided to set up a 500-member Special Reserve Force to strengthen efforts to prevent wild elephant attacks and reduce human-wildlife conflict in vulnerable areas across the State.

The decision was announced by Forest Minister Shibu Baby John amid growing concerns over the impact of wild elephant incursions on people's lives, particularly in forest-fringe villages. At least six people have been killed in wild elephant attacks across the State over the past two weeks.

According to the minister, the force will consist of 100 units with five members each and will be deployed in hotspots where the presence of wild elephants is frequently reported.

The Special Reserve Force will include members of tribal communities familiar with wildlife habitats, retired forest department experts, experienced residents and people with technical expertise. The units will be stationed across the State.

"The force is being formed to avoid risks arising from wildlife and to make human-wildlife conflict mitigation more effective," the minister said.

Bihar CM transfers ₹1,100 each to 94 lakh beneficiaries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Wednesday transferred ₹1,100 each to the bank accounts of more than 94 lakh beneficiaries of various social security schemes to mark Narendra Modi setting the record of being the longest serving elected prime minister of the country.

The CM transferred the amount under six schemes of the State Government, including those for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities, at a programme.

The Bihar Government had last year increased the monthly pensions of senior citizens, widows and people with disabilities from ₹400 to ₹1,100. According to a statement issued by the chief minister's office here, "On the



occasion of Narendra Modi completing the longest tenure as an elected prime minister, the CM transferred a pension of ₹1,100 each directly to the bank accounts of more than 94 lakh beneficiaries. The CM said providing social security to Bihar's poor, deprived, and needy sections is the responsibility of his Government."

Failure is a gateway to success, not an end: Delhi LG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday told a youth delegation from Chhattisgarh that no examination or competition can ever be worth more than a human life, expressing deep concern over young people falling into depression or ending their lives after failing to clear exams, and urging them to remember that failure is simply a gateway to success and not a reason to give up.

The LG was interacting with students participating in Yuva Sangam Phase VI at Lok Niwas. The delegation, comprising students from diverse academic backgrounds including fine arts, commerce, science, and technology, is visiting Delhi



under the programme led by IIT Bhilai and hosted by IIT Delhi.

Responding to questions from students on leadership, public service, and his experiences as a diplomat, Sandhu said India's youthful population presents an unprecedented opportunity for growth and innovation that most ageing developed

nations do not have. He said the country's demographic advantage can only be converted into lasting strength if young people continuously identify, nurture, and enhance their skills. "India's demographic dividend can become its greatest strength when young people continuously identify, nurture, and

enhance their skills. Success begins with self-reflection and a clear understanding of one's strengths and aspirations. Do not be afraid of failure, as it is an integral part of every journey of growth and achievement. What is important is to remain resilient, keep learning, and never give up," Sandhu said.

On the question of students taking extreme steps after examination failure, the LG was direct. He said this is completely wrong and must not happen. No exam or competition can ever be more valuable than life itself, he told the students. On technology, Sandhu emphasised that the future belongs not to those who understand Artificial Intelligence in theory but to those who can implement it practical-

ly in the real world. He said AI cannot function independently and that human presence and guidance will always be essential to run and manage it. He called on students to master the technology-machine-human synergy and use it for the betterment of society.

He also highlighted emerging opportunities in sectors such as religious tourism, encouraging the youth to identify areas capable of generating employment, strengthening local economies, and creating sustainable impact.

Yuva Sangam is a flagship youth exchange programme under the Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat initiative of the Ministry of Education. It is built around five pillars: tourism, traditions, development, people-to-people connections, and technology.



Editor's
TAKE

PoK burns while
Pakistan looks away

Economic despair, democratic deficits
and a heavy-handed crackdown on the JAAC
movement have pushed it to its brink in years

The streets of Muzaffarabad, Rawalakot, and Mirpur do not burn without reason. What began as a campaign for subsidised flour and affordable electricity by the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) has morphed into a full-blown political rebellion against Islamabad's grip on Pakistan-administered Kashmir. Markets are shuttered, paramilitary boots are on the ground, and at least eleven protesters have been killed in clashes with security forces. Islamabad's response – banning the JAAC, placing bounties on its leaders, and flooding the region with federal forces – has only poured fuel on the fire. The unrest is rooted in decades of structural grievance. The JAAC's central demand - abolishing the twelve legislative seats reserved for 1947 Jammu and Kashmir refugees settled in mainland Pakistan - strikes at the heart of PoK's political dysfunction. These seats have long allowed Islamabad's favoured parties to engineer governments in Muzaffarabad, bypassing the will of local voters. Combine this with punishing electricity tariffs, a cost-of-living crisis, and persistent constitutional ambiguity about the region's status, and the tinder was always there. The JAAC simply lit the match.

Faisal Mumtaz Rathore's appeals for dialogue ring hollow when made alongside mass arrests, communication clampdowns, and a ₹10 million bounty on protest leaders. The Human Rights Commission of Pakistan has warned that suppressing popular movements erodes democratic legitimacy – advice Islamabad appears unwilling to heed.

British MPs, diaspora Kashmiris outside the Pakistani Consulate in Bradford, and international observers are all watching. The crackdown is becoming a reputational liability for Pakistan far beyond the region itself. New Delhi must watch this situation with clear eyes and a steady hand.

The temptation to exploit the crisis with triumphalist commentary should be firmly resisted – it would only hand Islamabad a nationalist distraction. Instead, India should pursue a multi-pronged approach. First, it must amplify the voices of PoK's people in international forums – not as a propaganda exercise, but as a principled defence of democratic rights and self-determination, values India espouses globally.

Second, New Delhi should engage the Kashmiri diaspora in the UK and elsewhere, whose protests against Pakistani conduct now align with India's long-standing legal position that PoK is illegally occupied territory.

Third, and most critically, India must ensure that its own conduct in Jammu and Kashmir remains beyond reproach. The moral authority to speak on PoK's democratic deficit is strongest when the Indian side of the Line of Control is seen as a genuine model of governance, economic development, and political participation. Besides, New Delhi must ensure that the Kashmir Valley remains peaceful, even if Pakistan tries to foment trouble to deflect the attention of the international community. Every hospital built in Ladakh and every elected panchayat functioning freely in the Valley is a more powerful statement than any diplomatic demarche.

Bihar's silent land records revolution

The future of land governance in India may not always emerge from the courtrooms, but from transparent, continuously updated, digitally secured revenue records



VIVEK
KUMAR
SINGH

India's economy runs on land records, but its legal imagination has never fully trusted them. Few administrative instruments have been as routinely dismissed as mutation entries – long treated as weak fiscal documents carrying little evidentiary value regarding ownership. Courts have repeatedly observed that mutation neither creates nor extinguishes title. Lawyers have viewed it as merely presumptive. Citizens have associated revenue records with manipulation, missing registers, opaque procedures, and arbitrary correction slips.

Much of this scepticism was justified – but it was justified in relation to a system that largely belonged to another era. The problem today is that India's legal discourse on mutation remains trapped in the past even as the architecture of land administration has changed dramatically in several states. One of the most striking examples of this transformation is Bihar, where a silent but far-reaching land records revolution has unfolded over the last decade.

Bihar was not an early mover in digitisation. Having embarked upon it as late as in 2017-18, within a short span, it emerged as one of the country's most ambitious reformers, eventually being recognised as the most progressive state on the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER) Land Records and Services Index in 2021. What makes Bihar's experience particularly significant is that the reform was not merely technological. It was simultaneously legal, procedural, and institutional.

The state adopted what may be described as a “3-D Strategy” – Digitise, Distil, Deliver. The challenge before Bihar was uniquely complex. Zamindari-era land records carried enormous inconsistencies, missing links, overlapping claims, and fragmented documentation accumulated over generations. Mere scanning of old records could not solve the problem. Data had to be cleaned, reconciled, standardised, and continuously updated. Digitisation was, therefore, accompanied by distillation – validation, correction, integration, and dynamic updation of records through a transparent process ‘Parimarjan’ (meaning refurbishment). Without this process, digitisation would merely have fossilised historical inaccuracies into electronic form. The final stage was delivery. Technology was transformed into citizen-facing governance. Revenue services became increasingly online, transparent, and traceable.

Crucially, Bihar's reforms were not built on technology alone. They were anchored in legal restructuring. Prior to the reforms of the last



CERTAINLY, BIHAR'S
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THE SHEER SCALE
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CLAIMS, TENANCY
COMPLICATIONS,
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The writer is an ex-IAS officer and is presently Chairman, RERA Bihar. He served as Principal Secretary, Department of Revenue and Land Reforms, Bihar

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ilarly improved. Of the 4.19 lakh online cases filed before Deputy Collectors Land Reforms (DCLRs), approximately 2.57 lakh cases have been disposed of – a disposal rate of nearly 61 percent. Meanwhile, citizen access has steadily expanded. Today, 22 online services are available through the Bihar Bhumi portal, progressively transforming land governance into accessible e-governance.

One of the standard criticisms against land revenue proceedings has been that revenue officers lack the legal training of judicial officers. But this condemnation often overlooks the specialised nature of land administration itself. Most conventional LL.B. programmes devote limited attention to highly state-specific land revenue laws, jamabandi systems, tenancy frameworks, survey administration, and mutation procedures. Revenue officers, on the other hand, are trained precisely in these domains and continuously work within an ecosystem involving succession disputes, partition claims, transfers, inheritance, possession patterns, and cadastral realities.

None of this implies that revenue courts should replace civil courts, or make current revenue record entries assume the mantle of an infallible declaration of title. Fraudulent transfers, forged deeds, coercive transactions, and complex title disputes will always require judicial adjudication. Yet the traditional tendency to dismiss mutation records as casually maintained fiscal entries no longer reflects contemporary administrative reality. Modern mutated records increasingly operate as the de facto current title recognised by the state machinery. Banks rely upon them before sanctioning loans. Government agencies use them during compensation proceedings. Purchasers scrutinise them during transactions. Utilities and welfare systems increasingly depend upon them. The law may still stop short of granting conclusive de jure

status to mutation entries, but governance systems increasingly function on the assumption that mutation-backed records represent the current ownership framework.

Certainly, Bihar's challenges remain enormous. The sheer scale of its land-related ailments - historical gaps, overlapping claims, tenancy complications, survey inconsistencies, family partitions, and procedural delays – forebode that disputes and grievances are persistent, and may continue to be so. But within the limitations of India's land adjudication architecture, continuously updated and digitally secured mutation systems, like Bihar's, are gradually bringing method to what was once near-chaotic land administration. Bihar's experience demonstrates that land revenue administration need not remain trapped in the shadows of its past. The convergence of statutory safeguards, digitised records, geo-referenced mapping, transparent revenue adjudication, and continuous record updation can fundamentally alter the credibility index of land governance.

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The last lesson of life: Understanding death



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Death is the one destination we all share, yet it remains the most feared. No one wishes to die, and the uncertainty surrounding it fills our minds with dread, avoidance, and superstition. Yet ancient Yogis and Saints stood in striking contrast to this fear – they faced death with complete calm and awareness. This profound difference has long fascinated scientists and spiritual seekers alike, drawing them to study the dying process, particularly as experienced by those deeply rooted in spiritual practice.

It is said that Yogis receive an inner knowing when their time approaches. This awareness gives them the precious opportunity to settle unfinished attachments, ensuring that nothing pulls the mind back to the world at the critical moment when the soul departs.

Stabilised in soul-consciousness and absorbed in the loving remembrance of the Almighty, the Yogi experiences a gentle numbness beginning at the toes, with the soul gradually rising towards the forehead. The final karmic accounts are dissolved, and the soul – completely detached – feels neither physical pain nor emotional confusion. It simply rises and flies out through the forehead into higher, angelic realms.

This graceful exit is not accidental; it is the fruit of years, sometimes lifetimes, of sincere spiritual effort. For such a soul, death is not a doorway into darkness but a passage into light.

For those without such spiritual preparation, however, the experience is vastly different. At the moment of realisation that time is up, a flood of images rushes in – loved ones, unfinished business, unfulfilled desires, and a lifetime of actions, both good and bad.

Confusion and regret cloud the mind, and in this unsettled state, the soul departs without peace or clarity. The contrast is clear: the more one understands death from a spiritual perspective, the better one can prepare for it.

Many believe death is feared simply because it is unknown. But this overlooks a deeper truth. Every soul has left and entered bodies countless times; the experience of leaving is not truly foreign – it lives within our subconscious.

Death becomes painful primarily because we identify with the body, becoming so attached to it that the soul cannot leave peacefully. Deep emotional bonds, combined with the anguish of “I will never see them again”, intensify karmic ties and make the separation unbearable. This is why spiritual detachment, cultivated throughout life, becomes invaluable at the time of death. Unresolved emotions act like invisible chains, holding the soul back in sorrow even after it has left the body.

When a Yogi loses someone close, there is no grief – only understanding. Rather than weeping, the Yogi meditates and channels vibrations of peace towards the departed soul, helping it move forward quickly and painlessly into the next chapter.

A natural death at the end of a well-lived life carries with it a quiet inner voice: my part here is complete. According to ancient scriptures, death at the end of a full karmic cycle is the only death followed by true liberation.

To reach that state, one must actively renounce negative actions that create karmic bondage – conquering anger, greed, lust, arrogance, fear, and attachment – and choose to live a life of purity, awareness, and grace.

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The writer is a popular columnist and a spiritual teacher

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Zojila tunnel breakthrough

The Zojila Tunnel, at an elevation of 11,578 ft, is set to become India's longest road tunnel and will provide all-weather connectivity between Kashmir and Ladakh. The recent breakthrough near Minimarg, attended by Union Minister Nitin Gadkari, marks a significant milestone in India's infrastructure journey.

The 13.153-km single-tube, bi-directional tunnel is expected to open to the public in February 2028. Linking Baltal in Kashmir with Minimarg in Ladakh, it will end the seasonal isolation caused by the Zojila Pass and provide uninterrupted connectivity to Dras, Kargil, and Leh. Megha Engineering and Infrastructure Limited (MEIL), the executing agency, states that the tunnel will reduce travel time from 1.5-3 hours to about 15 minutes while meeting state-of-the-art safety standards. Beyond improving military logistics, the project is expected to boost year-round tourism, lower transport costs, reduce fuel consumption and emissions, facilitate faster movement of goods and services, and generate local employment. Often described as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's dream project, the Zojila Tunnel promises enhanced connectivity, security, and economic development for Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh.

RAJINDER NARULA | PATIALA

From welfare to growth

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has surpassed Jawaharlal Nehru's tenure as India's longest-serving elected Prime Minister. While this is an important political milestone, the true measure of leadership lies not merely in longevity but in the depth and durability of transformation. Over the past 12 years, India has witnessed a significant expansion of welfare delivery through direct benefit transfers, financial inclusion, rural housing, tap-water connectivity, and healthcare coverage. By reducing leakages and leveraging technology, the government has sought to make welfare more transparent and accessible. Equally noteworthy is the BJP's expansion into regions once considered beyond its political reach, reshaping the country's electoral landscape.

The next phase of governance, however, must move beyond welfare delivery towards wealth creation. Employment generation, skilling, quality education, urban planning, agricultural diversification, and climate resilience require greater attention. As India aspires to become a developed nation by 2047, success will depend on converting demographic potential into productive opportunities. The challenge now is to ensure that welfare gains translate into sustainable economic growth, social cohesion, and stronger institutions.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Protecting Nicobar's fragile ecosystem

The debate surrounding Great Nicobar has highlighted the island's strategic importance for India. Located near the Strait of Malacca, a maritime chokepoint through which a substantial share of global trade passes, the island is of undeniable geopolitical significance. India's desire to establish military and civilian infrastructure there is therefore understandable.

However, strategic necessity does not override ecological accountability. The proposed felling of 9.6 lakh trees across 130 square kilometres of tropical rainforest is not incidental to development; it is central to it. Coral reefs, leatherback turtle nesting grounds, and one of the world's last intact island biospheres cannot be protected through vague assurances alone. While the Ministry of Environment has acknowledged biodiversity concerns, details of effective mitigation measures remain unclear.

The situation of the Shompen community is equally troubling. With a population of only around 300, their homeland lies within the project footprint. Allegations that community consent was falsely certified warrant an independent inquiry. India needs neither a choice between strategy and ecology nor a false binary. What is required is an independent environmental review, transparent and genuine community consent before proceeding further.

M BARATHI | BENGALURU

FOUR DECADES LATER, JUSTICE FINALLY
REACHES APPELLANT

The Supreme Court's recent concern over a 40-year delay in the disposal of a criminal appeal by the Allahabad High Court highlights the urgent need for judicial reforms. A Bench comprising Justice Prashant Kumar Mishra and Justice Atul Chandurkar rightly described the situation as disturbing and sought solutions to tackle the mounting pendency that continues to burden the justice delivery system.

The case relates to Vijay Singh, who was arrested in 1983 for an alleged murder and was convicted by a Kanpur sessions court later that year. He challenged his conviction before the Allahabad High Court, only to see his appeal remain pending for four decades before being dismissed in February this year. Such an extraordinary delay undermines

faith in the judicial process and raises serious questions about access to timely justice.

Justice delayed is often justice denied. While courts across the country face a heavy caseload, delays of this magnitude are unacceptable. Prolonged litigation affects not only the accused but also victims, families, and society at large. It weakens public confidence in institutions and defeats the very purpose of the legal system.

Addressing judicial vacancies, improving case management, adopting technology, and creating additional benches are some measures that can help reduce pendency. The judiciary must ensure that justice is delivered not only fairly but also within a reasonable timeframe.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

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India’s era of cultural renaissance: Reclaiming our civilisational glory

India stands as one of the world’s oldest living civilisations. For centuries, our resilience was tested by brutal onslaughts from foreign invaders. Regimes changed and political power shifted, yet the core ethos of Bharat successfully endured, passed down seamlessly from one generation to the next



GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT

As India scales new heights across diverse sectors from economic robustness and national security to cutting-edge science and infrastructure - the path to becoming a truly Viksit Bharat (Developed India) demands more than just material milestones. True national progression requires an unyielding anchor in our ancient culture, history, and heritage.

India stands as one of the world's oldest living civilisations. For centuries, our resilience was tested by brutal onslaughts from foreign invaders. Regimes changed and political power shifted, yet the core ethos of Bharat successfully endured, passed down seamlessly from one generation to the next. Though our sacred places of worship, ancient texts, libraries, and universities were systematically demolished during these turbulent eras, our cultural soul remained indomitable.

However, the most insidious blow to cultural India came later through a systematically altered education system. This framework was deliberately engineered to instil a deep-seated inferiority complex within us towards our own heritage, intentionally severing us from our civilisational roots.

2014: The dawn of a cultural reawakening

The year 2014 marked a historic paradigm shift. Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, India began shedding its colonial cloak and initiated a massive cultural resurrection. Today, a confident Bharat is not merely recalling its glorious past; it is actively restoring its grandeur, majesty, and spiritual values to the very fabric of our mainstream social life.

Our timeless festivals, historical monuments, traditional cuisine, attire, fine arts, music, and profound craftsmanship are no longer viewed as mere relics of history — they have emerged as dynamic pillars of global fascination and respect.

Activating India’s cultural soft power

Over the past 12 years, the global acceptance and appreciation of Indian heritage have reached unprecedented heights. The universal adoption of June 21 as International Day of Yoga is a spectacular example. Yoga is not merely a physical regimen; it is a profound ancient Indian philosophy that the world has embraced for holistic human well-being.

Our commitment to our heritage is equally reflected in the aggressive repatriation of stolen antiquities, marking a sharp departure from past decades of institutional apathy:

- Prior to 2013: A mere 13 stolen artefacts were brought back to India over several decades.
- Past 12 Years: More than 640 sacred heritage artefacts have been successfully retrieved from foreign soil.

This overwhelming shift proves that preserving culture is no longer just a rhetorical exercise; we are fiercely determined to reclaim the physical and spiritual symbols of our civilisation. These artefacts are the living imprints of our ancestors' mastery of art, craft, and science, serving as eternal beacons of inspiration.

Furthermore, UNESCO's recognition of Durga Puja and Diwali as Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity validates the timeless, universal messages embedded in our traditions — the eternal triumph of truth over falsehood and light over darkness. With 44 World Heritage Sites, India now ranks sixth globally and second in Asia, offering proud testimony to our tangible historical legacy.

Reclaiming forgotten and suppressed knowledge

For centuries, foreign forces that lacked respect for intellectual and spiritual traditions tried to obliterate India's knowledge repositories by burning our universities, dismantling gurukuls, and scattering our manuscripts. While dedicated sages and households quietly preserved these priceless manuscripts in remote monasteries and temples, they unfortunately slipped from public memory. Regrettably, even after gaining independence, past regimes made no structured, national-level effort to compile these texts and



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THROUGH ICONIC TRANSFORMATIONS SUCH AS THE KASHI VISHWANATH DHAM, MAHAKAL LOK CORRIDOR, KEDARNATH, AND SOMNATH, WE ARE EXECUTING A COMPREHENSIVE OVERHAUL OF OUR SPIRITUAL LANDSCAPE. BY CREATING WORLD-CLASS INFRASTRUCTURE AND SEAMLESS FACILITIES FOR PILGRIMS, WE HAVE SUCCESSFULLY CHAMPIONED THE PHILOSOPHY OF ‘VIRASAT BHI, VIKAS BHI’ (HERITAGE ALONGSIDE DEVELOPMENT)

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reclaim our civilisational wisdom.

To rectify this historic oversight, the ‘Gyan Bharatam’ National Manuscript Survey has been launched as a massive nationwide initiative. Today, over 1 crore manuscripts have been successfully catalogued from across the country.

We are not just collecting these texts; we are pairing ancient wisdom with modern technological capability. By leveraging cutting-edge tools such as Artificial Intelligence (AI) and advanced digitisation, we are securing this intellectual wealth for posterity. This monumental archive will introduce future generations to India's historic excellence in spirituality, science, art, and craft, inspiring an unshakeable pride in their roots.

Virasat Bhi, Vikas Bhi: Rejuvenating our sacred places

Our grand temples, imposing forts, and historical fairs are the physical anchors of our civilisational narrative. Yet, for nearly seven decades after independence, these cultural landmarks faced systemic neglect and administrative apathy, while only a select few monuments were curated for global visibility. Temples in India have historically been the unifying threads of our diverse social fabric. Over the past 12 years, we have completely reversed this culture of neglect.

Through iconic transformations such as the Kashi Vishwanath Dham, Mahakal Lok Corridor, Kedarnath, and Somnath, we are executing a comprehensive overhaul of our spiritual landscape. By creating world-class infrastructure and seamless facilities for pilgrims, we have successfully championed the philosophy of ‘Virasat Bhi, Vikas Bhi’ (Heritage alongside Development).

This revitalisation has sparked a massive boom in spiritual tourism, directly strengthening local economies and transforming these holy towns into vibrant economic hubs.

Most heartening is the massive influx of young people to these sacred centres. Their growing presence is the ultimate symbol of India's cultural revival, proving that our younger generation is eagerly re-establishing its bond with our spiritual heritage.

Bharat reconnecting with its eternal roots

Today, India is confidently walking a dual path: keeping pace with the cutting-edge modern world while remaining deeply anchored in its ancient civilisational roots. We are writing a glorious new chapter of cultural decolonisation. After centuries of existential struggle, Bharat is firmly asserting its timeless spiritual and cultural identity on the global stage.

We are demonstrating to the world how ancient traditions and state-of-the-art modernity can seamlessly coexist. The future belongs to this vibrant, self-reliant New India. In this Amrit Kaal, the thought, philosophy, and cultural values of Bharat are poised to give a fresh, holistic direction to the global community.

NEET & the crisis of trust



AASHISH CHAUDHRY

Every year, lakhs of young students across India prepare for one dream — becoming a doctor. For many families, NEET is not just an exam. It is years of sacrifice, hard work, coaching classes, sleepless nights, and emotional pressure. Parents invest their savings. Students give up festivals, holidays, and social life. They study with the hope that their efforts will decide their future fairly.

Having gone through the same process in 1996, I am well aware of the stress and anxiety that students face when they feel that their fate is at stake. This kind of easy access to exam papers is highly regrettable. I really empathise with the plight of the students. Such acts create serious doubts about the validity of the system, as well as put tremendous pressure on students, parents, and the government. Any allegation of a paper leak or exam irregularity deeply hurts not only students but also the faith of the entire nation. NEET-UG is today one of the largest entrance examinations in the world. As per reports, NEET-UG 2026 was held in over 551 cities in India and 14 foreign countries, at over 5,400 exam centres. Around 22.8 lakh students registered for the test, while over 22 lakh appeared. After reports of paper leakage, the examination will now be conducted again in June. The exam is also linked to a massive medical education system. India reportedly has more than 1.28 lakh MBBS seats across over 800 medical colleges. Along with this, there are thousands of seats in dental and AYUSH colleges. The future healthcare workforce of India begins with this one examination.

Exams such as NEET should reflect honesty, merit, discipline, and equal opportunities. Students must believe that their efforts have value. Over the last few years, allegations related to paper leaks and cheating have repeatedly raised concerns. Whether proven or under investigation, such incidents damage public trust.

The biggest impact is not only administrative but also emotional. Students preparing for NEET already face extreme pressure. Many study for years. Some repeat attempts multiple times. They live under constant stress, and when reports of leaks or unfair practices emerge, students start feeling helpless. This uncertainty even affects their mental health. Today, anxiety, burnout, sleep problems, depression, and emotional exhaustion are becoming common among competitive exam students.

Parents also silently suffer. In many homes, the entire family's routine revolves around the child preparing for NEET. Expectations become very high. If trust in the system weakens, stress increases further.

As doctors, we often talk about mental wellness, but we must also understand the mental pressure created by academic systems. A student preparing for medicine should not feel broken before even entering medical college.

At the same time, we must also acknowledge the positive side. Conducting an examination of this scale is not easy. The conduct of examinations for lakhs of students in thousands of centres requires tremendous coordination, manpower, and security. There are many officials, teachers, administrators, and staff members who genuinely try their best for the smooth conduct of the examination. We must also appreciate their efforts.

However, in the present era of technology, it is not sufficient. India is an IT nation. If technology can secure the banking system, digital payment systems, and national databases, then surely the examination system can also be improved. Artificial intelligence and data analytics could be used for the detection of anomalies in students' answers. If a group of candidates shows highly abnormal answer similarities, systems can immediately flag it for investigation. This can help detect organised cheating networks early.

There is a need to strengthen biometric authentication and standardise it across all NEET examination centres in the country. Facial recognition, fingerprint scanning, and live verification can minimise impersonation and fraudulent candidate entry. There is a need to make sure that question paper movement becomes totally encrypted and digitally traceable. All stages, from printing to transporting, storing, and distributing papers, have to be digitally tracked in real time.

Technology can play an important role in monitoring examination centres. AI-enabled CCTV systems can detect suspicious activity, while live monitoring from central control rooms can improve transparency. Multiple paper sets generated through secure algorithms can further reduce the risk of leaks. Cybersecurity must also become a priority for examination bodies. Stronger cyber audits, ethical hacking tests, and independent technology reviews should be mandatory before every major national examination.

In addition, we also need institutional accountability. In the case of any irregularities, the process of investigation should be quick, unbiased, and fair. Information should reach students immediately rather than creating rumours and chaos. Any delay will increase panic. Strict punishment is equally important. When people leak papers, they are not just committing an act against the system; they are robbing honest students of opportunities. Strict legal action can instil fear among such groups indulging in malpractices. It is also necessary to decrease over-centralisation. India is a vast and diverse nation. According to some experts, states should play an active role in counselling, monitoring, and conducting exams. The pressure around a single examination is another major issue. For lakhs of students, one exam decides everything. This creates enormous stress. India should gradually explore systems where academic performance, aptitude, practical assessment, and multiple opportunities also play a role in admissions. A single three-hour exam should not completely define a student's worth or future.

Career counselling is equally important. Not qualifying for NEET should not be seen as failure. India needs skilled professionals in many healthcare fields - nursing, physiotherapy, psychology, public health, biotechnology, research, and allied sciences. Society must stop treating only MBBS degrees as success.

Parents also play a very important role during such crises. Students preparing for competitive exams need emotional support more than pressure. They need reassurance that their value as individuals is worth more than mere marks and rankings. I firmly believe that the future of medicine lies in the psychological health of students choosing this field. A stressed, exhausted, and emotionally damaged student cannot become a compassionate doctor easily. The NEET examination system does not only select future doctors. It shapes the future culture of Indian healthcare.

India has the talent, technology, and administrative strength to make NEET more secure and transparent. What is needed now is continuous reform, political will, institutional responsibility, and student-first thinking. Lakhs of students are not asking for shortcuts. They are simply asking for fairness. And fairness is the minimum any young dream deserves.



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From efficiency to sustainability: The evolution of conscious industry



SHARMILA DAS

I remember walking into the meeting where Six Sigma was to be introduced. Our CEO asked if I knew what it stood for. In those pre-Google days, I reached for common sense and humour: 'If it's American, it must be simple.' As it turned out, the very first line of the presentation read: "Six Sigma plugs the hole in the bucket." We made eye contact and laughed. But beneath the simplicity, the concept was powerful.

Six Sigma became the gold standard of industrial discipline. If you were a certified champion, those credentials walked into the room slightly ahead of you — much like a pot belly. Factories embraced it. Production lines worshipped it. Consultants built empires around it. And, to be fair, it worked. The manufacturing world became sharper, faster, cleaner, and more accountable. Every scrap of excess material, every unnecessary movement, every defective output was treated as a leak in a carefully engineered system. The goal was simple: preserve value by eliminating waste.

But nearly a quarter of a century later, humanity discovered something larger. The bucket itself was leaking — not merely in factories or supply chains, but in ecosystems, lifestyles, cities, oceans, and our very relationship with consumption itself.

That is where sustainability quietly entered - not as a replacement for efficiency, but as its natural evolution. Because sustainability, in many ways, is Six Sigma expanded to life itself.

Today, the conversation is no longer only about how efficiently we manufacture fabric. It is about what happens to everything left behind once manufacturing is complete — the offcuts, the trims, the rejected panels, the tiny mountains of discarded material that silently accumulate across the world every single day. For decades, fabric scraps were treated as unavoidable industrial residue: too small to value, too inconvenient to process, too insignificant to discuss. But sustainability changes the lens entirely.

What if the scrap is not waste? What if it is simply material waiting for its next identity?

A discarded fragment today can become insulation tomorrow, handcrafted accessories, regenerated yarn, or even the design statement itself. Reuse and recreation are no longer experiments in niche studios. They are becoming central to the future of responsible manufacturing. The beauty of fabric is that, unlike many materials, it carries memory — texture, history, energy. A scrap is not dead matter. It is unfinished possibility.

This is why the philosophy of textile reuse feels so connected to the ancient wisdom of Yoga. At



its core, Yoga is not merely exercise. It is alignment. It teaches that waste occurs the moment there is disconnection — between breath and awareness, between movement and intention, between body and mind. The moment we lose consciousness of how energy flows through us, imbalance begins.

The same principle applies to sustainability. Modern consumption has functioned like a body breathing incorrectly. We inhale endlessly through production, extraction, and acquisition — but we have forgotten how to exhale responsibly through reuse, restoration, and mindful circulation. The result is imbalance: overflowing landfills, pollut-

ed rivers, burning textile waste, and societies consuming faster than they can emotionally process.

Yoga reminds us that health lies in circulation, not accumulation. Nothing in nature wastes itself — a fallen leaf becomes soil, a river recycles its own journey. Sustainability is, in this sense, industrial yoga. It asks industries to move with awareness, to understand that every output carries a consequence and every resource deserves respect.

In traditional manufacturing, scraps represented inefficiency. In sustainable systems, they represent opportunity. That single change in perception is revolutionary. When designers build collections around leftover materials, creativity transforms. When factories intelligently segregate scraps, systems transform. When consumers value recreated products, markets transform. And when businesses measure not only profit margins but also environmental footprints, priorities transform.

The remarkable thing is that sustainability has moved far beyond environmental activism - it has become operational intelligence. The companies shaping the future are no longer simply those producing the fastest or cheapest products. Increasingly, they are those designing circular systems where materials stay in motion longer, waste is minimised before it exists, and regeneration is built into strategy itself.

Six Sigma taught us how to control defects in manufacturing. Sustainability asks us to examine defects in behaviour.

Six Sigma asked: How do we reduce wastage inside the factory? Sustainability asks: How do we

reduce wastage within civilisation?

It is no longer enough for a process to be efficient if the planet supporting that process becomes inefficiently burdened.

And perhaps the most hopeful part of this transition is that creativity is returning to industry. For years, mass production rewarded uniformity. Now sustainability rewards imagination. A recreated fabric panel carries character. A repaired garment feels personal in ways a new one rarely does. Imperfection becomes individuality rather than failure. Yoga teaches acceptance — not of stagnation, but of transformation. A stiff body can grow flexible. A fragmented life can become integrated. Likewise, a fragmented textile can become whole again. The scrap is not the end of the story. It is simply the pause before reinvention.

Value does not disappear merely because form changes. A cutting on a factory floor still holds purpose. A repaired product still carries dignity. A recreated object still possesses beauty.

We are entering an era in which the most admired industries may not be those that produce the most, but those that waste the least while creating the most meaning. The future belongs not to those who build bigger buckets — but to those who finally learn how to stop the leaking altogether.

The writer is a trained Sivananda Yoga teacher

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Signature forgery: HC to hear Abhishek's plea on Thursday

The Calcutta High Court on Wednesday said it will hear on Thursday Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee's plea seeking protection from any coercive action by the state CID over its probe into alleged forgery of party MLAs' signatures.

Moving the court of Justice Kausik Chanda, the TMC leader's advocate Kalyan Banerjee sought an urgent hearing, saying that the Diamond Harbour MP's office was raided by the CID on Tuesday in his absence.

Justice Chanda said that the petition will be heard on Thursday. The Diamond Harbour MP moved the court seeking protection from any coercive action by the CID and quashing of the FIR in the signature forgery case against him. The CID is conducting the probe based on a complaint by two legislators to the Assembly Secretariat that their signatures in the TMC's resolution for appointing Ballygunge MLA Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay as the leader of the opposition were forged.

The Assembly Secretariat filed an FIR with the Kolkata Police over the complaint by the MLAs – Ritabrata Banerjee and Sandipan Saha – and the probe was later transferred to the CID by the state's home secretary.

The legislators were later expelled from the TMC for "anti-party activities". (PTI)

Conversion case: Court denies bail to woman, her father

A court here has rejected the bail applications of a woman and her father in connection with an alleged forced conversion case of a 30-year-old man, officials said on Wednesday.

Chief Judicial Magistrate Akshay Yadav on Tuesday rejected the bail pleas of Chandni Qureshi and her father Islam Qureshi on Tuesday, observing that no grounds for granting bail were made out in the case. According to prosecution officer UK Johri, a case was registered against nine persons, including a cleric following a complaint lodged by medicine trader Devraj Malik. The complainant alleged that his son, Ayush Malik (30), was converted to Islam on the pretext of marriage with Chandni Qureshi and that the conversion was part of a conspiracy to gain control over his property. He also alleged that Ayush was taken to Delhi, where the marriage ceremony was conducted using forged documents. (PTI)

Calcutta HC grants interim protection to WB ex-sports minister in Messi event chaos case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Wednesday granted interim protection to former West Bengal sports minister Aroop Biswas from any coercive action in a case related to the chaos at the Lionel Messi event at Salt Lake Stadium in December.

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya directed Biswas, who did not comply with two notices sent by the Bidhannagar police to appear before it for questioning, not to leave station without the court's permission.



Biswas was directed to submit his passport to the trial court within seven days.

The High Court also directed the former minister to appear before the probe agency on a notice by it, which is to be served on him at least 48 hours prior.

During the hearing, Justice Bhattacharyya said everyone was ashamed about the incident as Messi had to leave the Salt Lake stadium. The court observed that there were too many people on the ground that day, and the petitioner was the sports minister then. The matter will come up for hearing again on August 4.



Tax evasion case: Anil Ambani gets interim protection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court has granted interim protection from prosecution and penalty to industrialist Anil Ambani in an alleged tax evasion case, while admitting his petition challenging constitutional validity of provisions of Black Money Act.

Ambani, in his plea, said certain provisions of the (Undisclosed Foreign Income and Assets) and Imposition of Tax Act, 2015, were "ultra vires" (beyond the powers/violative) to the Constitution of India.

A bench of Justices B P Colabawalla and Firdosh

Pooniwalla on Tuesday noted that there are other petitions filed in HC against the Act and admitted Ambani's plea, which will be taken up for final hearing in due course. The court directed the Union government to file its affidavit in response to the plea. The HC noted that an assessment order against Ambani has already been passed and that he has filed an appeal before the Commissioner of Income Tax (Appeals).

"The said appeal can proceed and orders can be passed thereon. However, we clarify that no coercive action shall be taken against the petitioner, including that



of prosecution and penalty, till the hearing and final disposal of this writ petition," the HC said.

The Income Tax department issued a notice to Ambani on August 8, 2022, for allegedly evading ₹420 crore

in taxes on undisclosed funds of more than ₹814 crore held in two Swiss bank accounts.

As per the department's notice, Ambani was liable to be prosecuted under Sections 50 and 51 of the Black Money Act, which stipulates a maximum punishment of 10 years imprisonment with a fine. The department has charged Ambani with "wilful" evasion, claiming he "intentionally" did not disclose his foreign bank account details and financial interests to Indian tax authorities.

Ambani, in his petition, claimed that the Black Money Act was enacted in 2015, and the alleged transactions are

of assessment years 2006-2007 and 2010-2011. As per his plea, provisions of Act cannot have retrospective effect.

According to I-T department's notice, Ambani was an "economic contributor as well as beneficial owner" of a Bahamas-based entity called 'Diamond Trust' and another company called Northern Atlantic Trading Unlimited (NATU), which was incorporated in the British Virgin Islands (BVI).

The department alleged that Ambani "failed to disclose" these foreign assets in his income tax return (ITR) filings and hence contravened provisions of the Black Money Act.

Court stays FIR against Abhijit over posts on women journalists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has stayed a magistrate order directing registration of an FIR against political commentator Abhijit Iyer Mitra, saying that the alleged derogatory remarks against women journalists associated with news portal Newslandry were made in the form of "shayari".

Additional Sessions Judge Purshotam Pathak was hearing a revision petition filed by Mitra and allowed his plea seeking stay on the April 22 magistrate order.

In an order dated June 9, the court said, "The alleged



derogatory words are in the form of shayari but no individual has been specifically named therein and the meticulous interpretation of the words and sentences used

can only be done after hearing both the parties on merits on the revision petition." The revision petition challenged the magistrate court's direction to the Station Head

Officer (SHO) of Malviya Nagar police station to register an FIR on a complaint filed by journalist Manisha Pande and others.

The magistrate had said a police investigation was required to verify the user account from which the tweets were allegedly published. The judge observed that no prejudice would be caused to the complainants if the operation of the magistrate's order was stayed till final disposal of the revision petition.

The court said the action taken report filed by police appeared inconclusive and assistance of police officials

would be required to ascertain the "mens rea or motive", which could only be determined after hearing both parties. The sessions court also noted Mitra's argument that there was "no exigency for registration of FIR without hearing his defence."

During the proceedings before the sessions court, counsel for the complainants had opposed the stay plea and argued that Mitra's posts contained "vilification, derogatory shayari and explicitly sexually coloured remarks" targeting the women journalists and amounted to an attack on their dignity and integrity.

Allahabad HC asks State Government to compensate man kept in illegal custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has taken serious note of the illegal eight-day police custody of a man and directed the state government to give a compensation of Rs two lakh to him within six weeks. The court also ordered that the amount shall be recovered by the state government from the assistant commissioner of police, Bara, Prayagraj, after conducting disciplinary inquiry against him within three months.

Hearing a habeas corpus writ petition filed on behalf of Mansoor Ahmed, who hails from Prayagraj, a division bench comprising Justices Siddharth and Vinai Kumar



Dwivedi directed the commissioner of police (CP), commissionerate Prayagraj to file the compliance report of the order on or before September 14.

Directing to list the case on September 14, the court warned that in case of failure, the CP shall remain present before this court on the next date.

"This is a shocking state of

affairs in the Commissionerate, Prayagraj. The Commissioner of Police has been given the powers of a magistrate, which are being misused to the hilt. This court has considered a similar situation in a case pertaining to the Commissionerate, Ghazibad, (Chander Pal Singh and another Vs. State of UP) where the misuse of powers by the Commissioner of Police was also brought to the notice of the Court," the court said.

According to the petition, Krishan Mohan Singh, posted as station house officer (SHO), sub-inspector Umesh Singh, constables Ankit Singh and Tribhuvan Pandey allegedly forcibly entered the house of the Mansoor Ahmad and took him to the police station.

SC quashes POCSO case against man using extraordinary power

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Invoking its extraordinary authority under Article 142 of the Constitution, the Supreme Court has quashed the conviction of a man sentenced under the POCSO Act after noting that the victim has married the accused on attaining the age of majority.

Article 142 of the Constitution empowers the Supreme Court to pass any order necessary for doing "complete justice" in any cause pending before it to ensure justice.

In this case, the man and the woman fell in love while she was studying in class 12.



When he refused to marry her, she had filed a complaint against the man resulting in him being sentenced to 10 years under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act for having physical relations with a minor.

CJI MEETS INDIAN ENVOY IN UK, ASSURED OF SECURITY FOR FORMER HC JUDGE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant has taken up with the Indian High Commissioner the issue of death threats being issued to former Bombay High Court judge Justice Gautam Patel and his family, linked to a high-profile verdict.



The CJI, who is on an official visit to the United Kingdom, raised the issue with High Commissioner P Kumaran and has been assured that adequate security will be put in place for the former judge and his family. The meeting took place hours after Justice Patel revealed that a threatening letter had been delivered to his daughter's residence in London, sources said.

As per them, the CJI had a discussion with the High Commissioner, who assured him that no harm would come to Justice Patel or his family.

The threats stem from a landmark 2024 judgment delivered by Justice Patel regarding the succession and title of the Syedna, the spiritual leader of the million-strong Dawoodi Bohra community.

Allahabad HC directs Lucknow CP to submit report on missing minor girls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday directed the Lucknow Commissioner of Police to submit a detailed progress report on 34 minor girls who remain missing in the city, while taking note of police efforts that led to the recovery of 227 girls over the past six months.

The direction was issued by a Lucknow bench of Justice Praveen Kumar Giri during the hearing of a habeas corpus petition.

According to personal affidavits filed by the



Commissioner of Police and the Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP) of Lucknow, 261 minor girls were reported abducted, kidnapped, enticed away or missing during the period under review.

Union Govt clears appointment of 7 new judges to Patna High Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The Central government on Wednesday notified the appointment of seven lawyers as judges of the Patna High Court.

As per a notification issued by the Department of Justice, Ministry of Law and Justice, Advocates Ranjan Kumar Jha, Kumar Manish and Raj Kumar have been appointed as permanent judges of the Patna High Court, while Advocates Rana Vikram Singh, Vikash Kumar, Girijish Kumar and Alok Kumar have been appointed as Additional Judges.

In a post on X, Union law



minister Arjun Ram Meghwal shared, "In exercise of the powers conferred by the Constitution of India, in consultation with Chief Justice of India, the President is pleased to appoint the following Advocates as Judges / Additional Judges in the Patna High Court: Ranjan Kumar Jha, Kumar Manish and Raj Kumar as permanent judges, advocates Rana Vikram Singh, Vikash Kumar,

Girijish Kumar, and Alok Kumar as additional judges."

The Supreme Court Collegium had in February recommended names of nine Advocates for appointment as judges of the Patna High Court.

The appointments have been made under the constitutional framework governing judicial appointments to the High Courts and are expected to strengthen the functioning of the Patna High Court, which is presently operating below its sanctioned strength.

At present, the Patna High Court is functioning with 37 judges against a sanctioned strength of 53.

order or the trial's integrity, or "upload/share/disseminate or circulate any anti-national material".

Parvez, the programme coordinator of the Jammu and Kashmir Coalition of Civil Society and the chairperson of the Asian Federation Against Involuntary Disappearances, was arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on November 22, 2021.

The NIA had alleged that under the guise of human-rights activism, Parvez conspired with a Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) operative to run a network of overground workers (OGWs) for furthering the activities of the Pakistan-based terrorist organisation and committing terror acts in India. It had alleged that Parvez

was actively involved in collecting information regarding the movement of Army vehicles near the Line of Control (LoC), road conditions and details of Army camps, structures of the Army, paramilitary and police etc.

The NIA has charge-sheeted Parvez for several offences, including under sections 13 (punishment for unlawful activities), 18 (punishment for conspiracy etc.), 18B (punishment for recruiting of any person or persons for terrorist act), 38 (offence relating to membership of a terrorist organisation) and 39 (offence relating to support given to a terrorist organisation) of the UAPA and other sections under the Prevention of Corruption Act and the Indian Penal Code.

Delhi HC quashes FIR, ED case against NewsClick

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has quashed Economic Offences Wing (EOW's) FIR as well as Enforcement Directorate (ED) ECIR against news portal NewsClick and its editor-in-Chief Prabir Purkayastha registered over allegations of foreign funding.

Justice Neena Bansal Krishna held that even if the allegations in the FIR were accepted in entirety, the essential ingredients of offences under Sections 406 and 420 of IPC were not made out.

The Court further observed that the continuation of such FIR was nothing but a gross abuse of the process of law, thereby quashing the EOW FIR as well as the ECIR lodged by ED.

"It has been held that if the FIR under predicate offence is quashed, the ECIR automatically, is liable to be quashed. Consequently, the complete ECIR is also quashed. Once the ECIR itself is quashed, the prayer for supply of the copy of the

ECIR has become infructuous," the judge ruled.

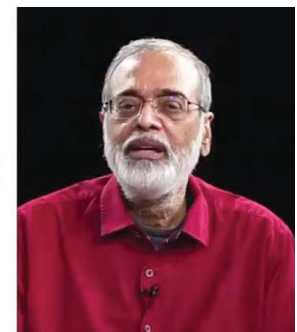
The FIR, registered in August 2020 on a complaint forwarded by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, alleged that NewsClick had received ₹9.59 crore in FDI from US-based Worldwide Media Holdings LLC through an allegedly overvalued share transaction designed to circumvent FDI restrictions.

It was alleged that a substantial portion of the funds was siphoned off through salaries, consultancy fees and other expenses. After due investigations, the copy of FIR was forwarded to the Enforcement Directorate and the ECIR was registered.

Quashing the cases, the Court said that it was an admitted position that M/s Worldwide Media Holdings LLC agreed to invest a total of USD 4.5 Million in three tranches of USD 1.5 M each in exchange of total 23.07 per cent shares of NewsClick's company PPK NewsClick Studio Pvt. Ltd.

It further noted that the first tranche of 1.5 Million was received by the platform on April 11, 2018.

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Juniper Green Energy commissions 305 MWp of renewable capacity in Gujarat

Juniper Green Energy on Wednesday said it has strengthened its footprint in Gujarat with the commissioning of 305 MWp of renewable capacity for Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Ltd. The company has commissioned projects across Surendranagar, Aravalli, Devbhumi Dwarka and adjoining districts of Gujarat.

According to a statement, Juniper Green Energy Ltd, a renewable energy independent power producer in India, has commissioned the projects under multiple Power Purchase Agreements (PPAs) signed with Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Ltd (GUVNL), through its subsidiaries. The commissioned portfolio comprises 183 MWp of solar capacity and 122 MW of wind capacity.

As part of the hybrid portfolio in Surendranagar, Aravalli and adjoining districts of Gujarat, Juniper Green Energy has commissioned 70.56 MWp of solar capacity under its 150 MW hybrid project on April 23, 2026 (commissioned 71 days ahead of the Scheduled Commercial Operation Date (SCOD)). The company has also commissioned 42.42 MWp of solar capacity under its 120 MW hybrid project on May 14, 2026 (commissioned 148 days ahead of the SCOD) and 70.07 MWp of solar capacity under another 150 MW hybrid project on June 3, 2026. In Devbhumi Dwarka, Juniper Green Energy has completed the commissioning of its two key projects --50.40 MW of wind capacity under its 50 MW wind power project and 72.45 MW under its 70 MW wind power project. "The successful commissioning of over 305 MW renewable energy capacity in Gujarat reflects Juniper Green Energy's strong project execution capabilities and commitment towards delivering sustainable, reliable clean energy solutions," said Ankush Malik, CEO - Juniper Green Energy. (PTI)

India-Oman trade pact to open huge export opportunities for labour-intensive sectors: Experts

India-Oman free trade agreement has opened huge export opportunities for domestic labour-intensive and value-added sectors such as textiles, gems and jewellery and marine products, experts say. Beyond goods, the comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) also sets the architecture for deeper services and mobility linkages, they said. The pact was operationalised on June 1. "Taken together, the CEPA does not merely lower tariffs; it builds a durable framework across goods, services, mobility and investment that should support a sustained step-up in bilateral commerce over the medium-term," Gulzar Didwania, Partner, Deloitte India, said.

He said that the most strategic dimension of the India-Oman CEPA is its contribution to India's energy security and supply-chain resilience. India remains a net importer of crude from Oman, with crude imports rising from around USD 0.1 billion in 2006 to USD 3.6 billion in 2022. The country has simultaneously built a meaningful export corridor in refined petroleum products, which peaked at USD 2.2 billion in 2022 before moderating to USD 1.3 billion in 2024. "That two-way structure reinforces the CEPA's relevance. It brings a more predictable framework to a relationship that is already commercially significant on both sides of the energy ledger and provides for a long-term trade strategy for the Gulf region," Didwania said.

Sanjay Budhia, Co-Chair, CII National Committee on Exports and Managing Director, Patton International Ltd, said the agreement will help boost bilateral trade relations.

"This agreement encompasses trade, investment, services, professional mobility, and regulatory cooperation, creating new opportunities for businesses in both countries," Budhia said. (PTI)

'Electronic manufacturing services market in India may grow to \$150 bn by FY30'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The electronics manufacturing services market may jump over threefold to USD 150 billion by 2030, driven by domestic demand, policy support and companies' strategy to diversify their supply chains beyond China, a KPMG report said on Wednesday.

India's Electronics manufacturing services (EMS) market has scaled rapidly to around USD 40-45 billion in FY25, a KPMG report titled India's Electronic Manufacturing Services (EMS) opportunity: From assembly hub to integrated manufac-

turing powerhouse, said. "India's EMS market has scaled rapidly to around USD 40-45 billion in FY25 and is expected to surpass around USD 150 billion by FY30, supported by exports, policy incentives and supply chain diversification," the report said. According to the report, India currently accounts for approximately 5-6 per cent of global EMS manufacturing, indicating significant headroom for growth.

Globally, electronics manufacturing is moving from cost optimisation to resilience-led, multi-node supply chains, with EMS players evolving into strategic partners for OEMs. The

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | JUNE 11, 2026

Industry lauds Modi on becoming longest serving Prime Minister

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India Inc congratulated Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday as he became the country's longest continuously serving PM, saying the nation has emerged as an influential global voice under his transformative leadership, with the 12-year tenure focused on sweeping reforms and driving inclusive economic development.

Industry leaders lauded the Narendra Modi-led government's emphasis on improving ease of doing business, saying that it has benefited from the enabling environment marked by increased investor confidence and that India Inc stands firmly with the prime minister in realising the Vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047. Confederation of Indian Industry Director General (CII) President R Mukundan said the growing confidence in India's capabilities is reflected in its resilience,

ambition, and continued progress towards becoming a leading global economic powerhouse.

"As India moves towards its vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, industry remains committed to working closely with the government to accelerate investment, strengthen competitiveness, create quality employment, and ensure that growth remains inclusive, sustainable, and future-ready," he added. FICCI President Anant Goenka said, "Congratulations to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on completing this landmark chapter in India's democratic

journey. The past twelve years have been characterised by the steady consolidation of India's economic fundamentals. Landmark reforms, enhanced ease of doing business, record infrastructure investments, expanding trade partnerships, stronger financial institutions and the rise of globally competitive manufacturing ecosystems have altered the trajectory of the Indian economy."

Echoing similar sentiments, CII Director General Chandrajit Banerjee said, "During this period, India has witnessed remarkable progress across

multiple fronts, strengthening its position as one of the world's leading economies and emerging as a confident global voice.

The country has made significant strides in inclusive economic development, infrastructure expansion, innovation, entrepreneurship, and social development".

He said the focus on reforms, efficient governance, and inclusive growth has enhanced India's resilience, competitiveness, and global standing. ASSOCHAM President Nirmal K Minda said during Modi's tenure, the country has emerged as a "bright spot" in the global economic system. "We are happy to note that the economy's growth fundamentals have performed as well as, or better than, those of any major economy in the world economic system. GDP has more than doubled from USD 1.9 trillion in 2013-14 to USD 4.1 trillion in 2025-26, supported by growth in the manufacturing and service sectors.

Airtel deploys over 2,900 new 5G sites in upper north region to boost network coverage

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu/Chandigarh

Telecom service operator Bharti Airtel on Wednesday said it has deployed more than 2,900 new 5G network sites across the upper north region over the past 12 months to ensure faster speed and better experience for its users.

Spanning 77 districts, the rollout provides reliable high-speed connectivity to over 28.6 million customers across bustling cities and fast-growing towns to remote rural villages of Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, and Jammu and Kashmir, the company said in a statement. With more than eight new

sites activated daily, users enjoy seamless streaming, rapid downloads, uninterrupted remote working and learning,

and dependable digital payments, regardless of their location, the statement said. "Data demand across Punjab, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir is surging, and we are staying ahead by relentlessly strengthening our network. These 2,900-plus new 5G sites mean faster speeds, wider coverage, and a more reliable experience for over 28.6 million customers.

"Our continued investments underscore Airtel's commitment to bridging connectivity gaps and powering the region's digital transformation with a future-ready network," said Anupam Arora, Chief Executive Officer, Upper North, Bharti Airtel.

TCPL growth will be mix of volume & price; eyes over 20% EBITDA margin: Chandrasekaran

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

FMCG major Tata Consumer Products Ltd (TCPL) will pursue a combination of volume-led growth and selective price increases to drive expansion, while targeting an EBITDA margin of over 20 per cent in the coming years, Chairman N Chandrasekaran said on Wednesday.

Addressing shareholders at the company's 63rd Annual General Meeting, Chandrasekaran said profitability would improve through a better product mix, higher volumes and contributions from newly launched categories.

"The growth will be both volume-based and pricing-based. The company is very clear that volume

growth is important because we cannot deliver growth only based on pricing," he said.

Chandrasekaran, who is also Chairman of Tata Sons, said volume growth would remain a key priority for the FMCG company even as it

undertakes selective price hikes to mitigate the impact of rising input costs. "The company is very clear that volume growth is important because we cannot deliver growth only through pricing," he said.

He added that price increases

become necessary when commodity costs rise sharply. "Whenever there is a significant increase in commodity prices, we have to take price increases, as we did in tea. But it is not always possible," Chandrasekaran said.

While replying to a query on Starbucks in India, he said it has the potential to expand to about 8,000 outlets over time.

Over future acquisitions by TCPL, Chandrasekaran said the company remains focused on ensuring that recent acquisitions generate strong growth and adequate returns on the capital invested, while continuing to evaluate new opportunities.

"The management and the board are conscious of the fact that capital has gone in, so we have to get the acquisitions to deliver strong

growth and returns on the capital that has been put in," he said.

Chandrasekaran said TCPL would continue to assess potential acquisitions to strengthen its portfolio, with investment decisions guided by value creation and capital efficiency. "At the same time, we will constantly evaluate any new opportunities to add to portfolio and the board will take right call," he said.

Addressing shareholder's concerns over profitability, TCPL is "operating around 14 per cent EBITDA margin. The company in medium term will look at 17 per cent and eventually goal is to cross 20 per cent EBITDA margin," he said adding "there has to be an improvement of 50 to 100 bps, in a good year 100 bps, in another years 50 bps at least."

No overcapacity in textiles, steel sectors in India: DGTR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India does not have surplus capacity in textiles and steel sectors, as per capita consumption of these products in the country remains among the lowest in the world, a senior government official said on Wednesday.

The remarks assume significance as the Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR) in March launched a probe regarding the acts, policies, and practices of various economies, including India, under Section 301(b) of the

Trade Act of 1974, relating to structural excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors.

Director General of Trade Remedies and Additional

Secretary in the commerce ministry Amitabh Kumar said that overcapacity has not come under any of the trade remedial laws in the WTO (World Trade Organization) framework and it is a new narrative.

"We do not think we have overcapacity in the textiles sector. Our per capita consumption of all kinds of textile products is abysmal, particularly in manmade fiber and technical textiles. Ours is a hot, tropical climate; we wear cotton. How do we have overcapacity?"

"In steel also, our per capita consumption is so low. We

have one of the lowest; we may be the second largest producer of steel, but compared to our population, our economic and growth imperative, it's one of the lowest," he told reporters here.

India is a net importer of manmade fibers, besides cotton. In its submission, India has rejected the allegations, and has stated that the USTR notice has not provided cogent rationale or prima facie evidence to substantiate its allegation that India has structural excess capacity in its major industries, leading to a trade surplus with the US.

move provides a significant, but time-bound, opportunity for India.

"While India leads in high-volume assembly, particularly in mobile and consumer electronics, its presence in higher-value areas, such as design, components and IP ownership, remains limited. "Value creation increases significantly with deeper integration, from assembly to design-led and system-level capabilities, making capability building across engineering, supply chains and product development a strategic priority," the report said.

High import dependency typically ranges from around

80 to over 95 per cent across critical components, and continues to limit domestic value addition and ecosystem maturity, it added.

"Policy interventions have been a critical growth enabler, with around USD 19.5 billion in cumulative incentives aimed at strengthening the electronics manufacturing ecosystem.

"Sustained competitiveness will depend on transitioning from capacity-led growth to capability-led growth, including localisation, certification depth, and design integration," the report said. The next five to ten years will be decisive for India, it noted.

India-US energy cooperation could help drive USD 500 bn trade goal by 2030: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Deeper cooperation in hydrocarbons could play a key role in helping India and the United States achieve their goal of expanding bilateral trade to USD 500 billion by 2030, according to a report released by the US-India Business Council (USIBC) and Grant Thornton Bharat.

The report, titled Strengthening the India-US Energy Partnership: Unlocking Hydrocarbon Opportunities through Investment and Collaboration, said the two countries' energy relationship is evolving beyond a traditional buyer-seller dynamic into a broader strategic partnership encompassing trade, investment, technology, infrastructure and energy security. The study identified opportunities to expand collaboration across liquefied natural gas (LNG), crude oil, liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), ethane and propane, while strengthening supply chains and energy security for both countries.

"The evolution of the India-US energy relationship reflects the broader trajectory of our bilateral partnership - moving from transactional engagement

to deeper strategic integration," Rahul Sharma, Managing Director of USIBC India, said in a statement.

"As trusted partners, India and the United States are uniquely positioned to collaborate across energy, technology and investment to strengthen energy security, support economic growth, and create new pathways for expanding bilateral trade in the years ahead," he added.

The report said rising energy demand in India and expanding US hydrocarbon production create opportunities for greater cross-border investment and commercial engagement across the energy value chain. "The India-US energy partnership is entering a new phase, one that extends beyond commodity trade to deeper collaboration across investment, technology, infrastructure and supply chains," said Amit Kumar, Partner and Energy and Renewables Industry Leader at Grant Thornton Bharat. "As India's energy needs continue to grow and the United States expands its role as a leading energy producer, hydrocarbons can serve as a powerful catalyst for advancing the shared goal of USD 500 billion in bilateral trade by 2030," he said.

Gold ETFs break 13-month streak

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Gold ETFs witnessed an outflow of ₹725 crore in May, breaking a 13-month streak of positive inflows, due to government appeals against purchasing the yellow metal and several asset management companies halting fresh inflows into these funds.

This was the first outflow since April 2025, when the Gold ETF saw a withdrawal of ₹5.82 crore. Overall, Gold ETFs (Exchange-Traded Funds) have attracted more than ₹70,000 crore since May 2025. According to data disclosed by the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) on Wednesday, Gold ETFs witnessed an outflow of ₹725 crore in May, against an inflow of ₹3,040 crore in April. The inflow stood at ₹2,266 crore in March, ₹5,255 crore in February and ₹24,040 crore in January. After strong inflows in

January, momentum tapered in subsequent months, indicating a gradual cooling in incremental allocations. The reversal appears to have been driven by a combination of profit booking following the earlier rally in gold prices and a shift in investor risk appetite, with some rotation away from safe-haven assets.

"With gold prices touching record highs, the government's request not to purchase gold, and some AMCs stopping inflows into ETFs, investors seem to be taking a more practical view," said Feroze Azeez, Joint CEO, Anand Rathii Wealth.

After a sharp rally, future returns may not look as attractive as they did over the past year. Some investors may also be booking profits and reallocating money towards other opportunities, especially equities that have corrected significantly, he added.

Jordan and India

Charting a stronger strategic future

The Pioneer
EXCLUSIVE



H.E. Yousef Abdelghani
Ambassador of the Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan



Dr. WAIEL AWWAD

As Jordan and India continue to deepen their strategic partnership, cooperation between the two nations is expanding across trade, investment, technology, energy, education, and regional security. With bilateral trade steadily growing and new opportunities emerging in high-value sectors, both countries are looking to build a more comprehensive and future-oriented relationship.

In this exclusive interview, Dr. Waiel Awwad speaks with the Ambassador of the Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan HE Yousef Abdelghani about the current state of Jordan-India relations, prospects for economic cooperation, regional developments, and a shared vision to elevate bilateral trade to US\$5 billion by 2030 while promoting stability, sustainable development, and stronger global partnerships.

Jordan-India Relations Enter a New Era of Strategic Partnership: An Exclusive Conversation with the Ambassador of Jordan HE Yousef Abdelghani and Dr Waiel Awwad

How would you describe the current state of Jordan-India relations?

Jordan and India enjoy exceptionally warm and friendly relations that are today stronger than ever before. Our partnership is rooted in decades of mutual respect, historical goodwill, and regular high-level engagement between our leadership. We share common perspectives on many regional and international issues and continue to deepen cooperation across political, economic, cultural, and security domains.

India has emerged as one of Jordan's most important economic partners, while Jordan serves as a trusted and reliable partner for India in the Middle East. Together, we support moderation, multilateralism, dialogue, and a reformed international rules-based order that reflects contemporary global realities.

What are the key priorities for enhancing bilateral cooperation in the coming years?

Our immediate priority is to diversify bilateral trade beyond traditional sectors

such as fertilizers and chemicals. While these remain vital pillars of our economic relationship, both countries possess tremendous opportunities in advanced manufacturing, information technology, digital services, renewable energy, healthcare, and innovation.

We are also focused on strengthening supply-chain resilience. Jordan plays an important role in supporting India's food security through phosphate and fertilizer exports, while India contributes significantly to Jordan's industrial development and technological advancement.

Furthermore, cooperation in digital public infrastructure, financial technology, artificial intelligence, and renewable energy systems offers exciting avenues for future growth.

Which sectors offer the greatest potential for trade and investment between Jordan and India?

Several sectors stand out as particularly promising.

First, phosphates and fertilizers remain the cornerstone of our economic partnership. Joint ventures such as the Jordan India Fertilizer Company (JIFCO) demonstrate the success of our collaboration and can be further expanded to meet India's growing agricultural requirements.

Second, information technology presents immense opportunities. India's globally recognized technological expertise complements Jordan's highly educated, multilingual, and technology-oriented youth population. Together, we can develop innovative fintech solutions, software products, and research initiatives.

Third, pharmaceuticals and healthcare represent another area of strong potential. Jordan possesses a robust export-oriented pharmaceutical sector, while India is a global leader in affordable pharmaceutical production. Joint ventures and contract manufacturing arrangements could benefit both countries significantly.

Textiles and garments also offer attractive prospects through Jordan's industrial zones, while renewable energy and green hydrogen projects can leverage Jordan's abundant solar and wind resources alongside Indian investment and technological capabilities.

How can Jordan serve as a gateway for Indian businesses seeking regional and global expansion?

Jordan offers Indian companies a unique strategic advantage. Through our extensive network of free trade agreements, businesses operating from Jordan enjoy preferential and duty-free access to major markets, including the United States, the European Union, and numerous Arab countries.

Our strategic location at the crossroads of Asia, Europe, and Africa, coupled with world-class infrastructure at the Port of Aqaba and specialized free zones, makes Jordan an ideal logistics and re-export hub.

Equally important is Jordan's reputation for stability, security, and regulatory predictability. Investors can confidently establish regional operations in Jordan while serving a market of hundreds of millions of consumers across multiple continents.

What role can India play in promoting stability and development in the Middle East?

India is increasingly recognized as an important economic and diplomatic actor in the region. Its growing trade relationships, infrastructure investments, and technology partnerships contribute significantly to economic development and prosperity.

India's ability to maintain constructive relations with all major regional stakeholders gives it a unique position to encourage dialogue and confidence-building. Jordan values India's balanced diplomatic approach and its consistent support for peaceful solutions to regional challenges.

In addition, initiatives such as the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) programme continue to make valuable contributions to human resource development and capacity building across the region.

How does Jordan view India's expanding strategic presence in the Arab world?

Jordan warmly welcomes India's active and constructive engagement across the Arab world. India has developed a mature and independent approach to regional diplomacy, building strong partnerships with countries throughout the region while respecting national sovereignty and regional sensitivities.

We see India's growing international stature as a positive force for multipolarity, economic cooperation, and conflict resolution. Greater Indian engagement contributes to regional stability and creates new opportunities for shared prosperity.

What is Jordan's assessment of the current regional security environment?

The Middle East continues to face complex challenges that require urgent and coordinated international action. Jordan consistently advocates de-escalation, humanitarian assistance, ceasefires where needed, and sustainable political solutions to ongoing conflicts.

We remain firmly convinced that lasting peace in the region cannot be achieved without a just and comprehensive resolution of the Palestinian issue based on the two-state solution.

Jordan also continues to shoulder a significant humanitarian responsibility by hosting large refugee populations. Sustained international cooperation and burden-sharing remain essential to ensuring regional stability and human security.

How can Jordan and India strengthen cooperation in defence, cybersecurity, and counterterrorism?

Security cooperation represents an increasingly important pillar of our relationship.

Jordan has gained valuable experience in countering violent extremism and promoting moderation through initiatives such as the Aqaba Process. We believe there is considerable scope for sharing institutional best practices with India and enhancing cooperation against radicalization and terrorism.

Cybersecurity is another critical area. Both countries face evolving threats to financial systems, telecommunications networks, and government infrastruc-

ture. Developing joint cybersecurity frameworks, information-sharing mechanisms, and capacity-building initiatives would be highly beneficial.

We also see opportunities for expanded military exchanges, training programmes, defence industry collaboration, and joint tactical workshops between our armed forces.

What opportunities exist for educational and cultural exchanges between the two countries?

People-to-people connections are the foundation of any enduring partnership.

We would welcome greater numbers of Jordanian students pursuing higher education in India's world-class universities and technology institutes. Expanded scholarship programmes, academic partnerships, and research collaboration can further strengthen these ties.

Tourism is another area of tremendous potential. Jordan's remarkable heritage sites, including Petra and Wadi Rum, have much to offer India's rapidly growing outbound tourism market.

Additionally, Jordan's diverse landscapes provide attractive and cost-effective filming destinations for the Indian film industry. Increased collaboration in

RELATIONS ARE AT AN ALL-TIME HIGH, BUILT ON DECADES OF FRIENDSHIP, MUTUAL RESPECT, AND SHARED VIEWS.

cinema, arts, and cultural exchanges can bring our societies even closer together.

What is your vision for Jordan-India relations by 2030?

Our vision is ambitious yet entirely achievable. We seek to elevate our relationship into a comprehensive strategic partnership supported by regular political dialogue, stronger economic institutions, and deeper people-to-people engagement.

By 2030, we aim to create fully integrated supply chains that combine Jordanian resources with Indian manufacturing and innovation capabilities. We also aspire to increase bilateral trade from the current level of approximately US\$3 billion to US\$5 billion.

Equally important, Jordan and India should work more closely within international forums to advance the interests of the Global South, promote sustainable development, support green transitions, and advocate for a more inclusive and representative international system.

The future of Jordan-India relations is exceptionally promising, and we are committed to translating that potential into tangible results for both our peoples.

Dr Waiel Awwad is Secretary General of India and Arab Countries Chamber of Commerce, Industry and Agriculture



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

India and Jordan: A partnership that must not be missed



ASHOKE RAJ

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's December visit to Jordan marked a pivotal moment in India's engagement with West Asia. It was significant not only because it coincided with the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations between India and Jordan, but also because it represented the first full-fledged state visit by an Indian Prime Minister to the Hashemite Kingdom.

For decades, despite warm diplomatic ties and mutual goodwill, India has not fully leveraged its relationship with Jordan. The visit signalled a recognition that Jordan is far more than a friendly nation—it is a strategic gateway to West Asia and the broader Arab world. As both countries commemorate 75 years of diplomatic engagement, the relationship is now entering a phase of deeper commitment and greater ambition.

The Real Prize: Trade and Business
India is already among Jordan's largest trading partners, yet bilateral trade remains well below its true potential. With both governments setting a target of \$5 billion in bilateral trade over the next five years, the existing gap should not be viewed as a limitation but as an opportunity.

The complementarities are evident. India brings world-class expertise in information technology, renewable

energy, pharmaceuticals, infrastructure development, and skilled workforce solutions. Jordan offers valuable phosphate and potash reserves, strategic geography, political stability, and access to regional markets. Together, these strengths form the basis of a natural economic partnership awaiting stronger execution.

The India-Jordan Business Forum held during the Prime Minister's visit reflected this reality. It was not merely a ceremonial gathering but a practical platform where entrepreneurs and investors from both nations explored avenues for collaboration, investment, and growth. The central question was straightforward: how can both countries create value together? Jordan is already a critical supplier of phosphates and potash for India's agricultural sector. However, the future of the relationship extends far beyond fertilizers.

Five Agreements, One Shared Vision

The signing of five Memorandums of Understanding covering renewable energy, water resource management, cultural exchange, digital solutions, and heritage-site cooperation offers a blueprint for the future of India-Jordan relations.

Renewable energy represents one of the most promising areas of cooperation. Jordan's abundant solar potential and India's leadership in cost-effective renewable technologies create opportunities for mutually beneficial projects that contribute to energy security and environmental sustainability.

Water management is equally critical. Water scarcity is emerging as one of the defining challenges of the twenty-first century. Jordan faces significant water constraints, while India has developed expertise in irrigation systems, water



Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets King Abdullah II in Jordan, December 2025

conservation, and resource management. Sharing knowledge and technology in this field addresses a pressing challenge while strengthening trust between the two nations.

Digital cooperation highlights another area where India can make a meaningful contribution. Indian technology companies have transformed industries worldwide through innovation and scalable digital solutions. Extending this expertise to Jordan can support economic modernization while creating opportunities for Indian businesses and professionals.

The cultural dimension should not be underestimated. The twinning of heritage sites such as Petra and Ellora may appear symbolic, but cultural diplomacy often produces tangible outcomes. It promotes tourism, encourages educational exchanges, and deepens people-to-people connections. Cultural under-

standing lays the foundation upon which stronger economic and strategic partnerships are built. These agreements are not isolated initiatives; they represent a coherent vision of what the India-Jordan partnership can become.

People-to-People Ties: The Unsung Bridge

One of the strongest pillars of the relationship is often overlooked: the people themselves. Approximately 17,500 Indian nationals live and work in Jordan across sectors including textiles, construction, healthcare, manufacturing, and services. These individuals contribute to Jordan's economy while strengthening India's presence abroad through remittances, professional excellence, and cultural engagement.

The recently renewed Cultural Exchange Programme for 2025-2029 provides an opportunity to deepen

these ties through educational collaborations, artistic exchanges, yoga initiatives, academic partnerships, and cultural performances.

Such interactions create an emotional connection between societies. When Jordanians engage with Indian culture, they gain a deeper understanding of India's values, diversity, and civilizational heritage. Likewise, Indians discover the rich history and traditions of Jordan. These exchanges generate trust, and trust remains the most valuable currency in international relations.

Standing Together Against Terrorism

India and Jordan share another important commonality: both have suffered from the consequences of terrorism and violent extremism.

This shared experience has created a strong foundation for cooperation on security issues. During the Prime Minister's visit, counterterrorism featured prominently in bilateral discussions, with Jordan expressing firm support for India's position on combating terrorism. Particularly significant is the alignment between India's policy of zero tolerance toward terrorism and King Abdullah II's promotion of the Amman Message, which rejects extremist interpretations of religion and condemns the use of faith to justify violence.

When two nations are united by common values and a shared understanding of security challenges, their partnership gains strategic depth. This alignment positions India and Jordan as credible partners in promoting regional stability and countering extremism.

Investing in Human Capital

Long-term partnerships are ultimately

built through investments in people.

India's decision to increase Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) training opportunities for Jordanian officials from 37 to 50 annually reflects this understanding. Such initiatives allow Jordanian professionals to gain exposure to Indian institutions, technologies, and development models while building enduring professional relationships.

Why Jordan Matters for India

In the twenty-first century, India's global ambitions require a diversified approach to international partnerships. While engagement with major powers remains important, India must also strengthen relationships with strategically located and politically stable partners across regions.

Jordan may not be a major power by conventional metrics, but its importance lies in its strategic location, regional credibility, and stability in a complex neighbourhood. It serves as a gateway to the broader Arab world and offers India an important platform for expanding its engagement across West Asia.

India requires reliable access to critical minerals, energy partnerships, and new markets for its goods and services. Jordan can contribute to each of these priorities. A stronger Jordan also contributes to regional stability, which directly benefits India's economic and security interests.

Furthermore, Jordan can amplify India's voice in the Arab world, helping strengthen India's diplomatic footprint across a region of increasing geopolitical importance.

The writer is an Associate Editor (Foreign Affairs) at The Pioneer.

PROSPECT

RIL, Meta partner to develop 168 MW AI enabled data centre in Gujarat's Jamnagar



Reliance Industries Limited and social media major Meta Platforms have partnered to develop a 168-megawatt data centre in Jamnagar, Gujarat, within two years, a joint statement said on Wednesday. This is the first built-to-suit data centre capacity in India for Meta and represents a significant milestone in India's emergence as a global hub for AI infrastructure, the statement said.

"RIL will develop a data centre with 168 MW capacity to be delivered within two years, with an option to scale. Meta will lease capacity from the facility," the statement said. The data centre will be powered by renewable energy and cooled with desalinated seawater.

Meta is also separately partnering with two leading clean energy providers in India, CleanMax and Fourth Partner Energy, to back nearly 1GW of renewable energy, the statement said. "This partnership with Meta marks a transformative moment for India's digital infrastructure. Building India's first built-to-suit data centre for a global technology leader of Meta's scale demonstrates India's readiness to be at the forefront of the global AI revolution," Reliance Industries Limited, Chairman and Managing Director, Mukesh Ambani said.

In active talks with Indian Govt, received encouraging feedback: Starlink



Elon Musk-led Starlink continues to be in active discussion with the Indian government and has received encouraging feedback on its capabilities to advance India's connectivity goals, a senior official of the satellite firm said on Wednesday. Starlink has applied for a licence to start satellite communications services in India. The government has issued a letter of intent to the company and the final license is awaited. "Starlink remains in active and productive discussions with the Government of India contrary to misleading stories based upon unsubstantiated claims from anonymous sources. We have worked with the Government through all of the required regulatory and compliance processes in a transparent and responsible manner," Lauren Dreyer, Vice President, Starlink Business Operations, said on social media platform X.

Maharashtra Govt signs MoU with Cleveland Clinic



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis on Wednesday announced that the Government of Maharashtra has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Cleveland Clinic, Brookfield Asset Management and Arohdhan Health City to develop the Navi Mumbai International MediCity (NMIMC), a healthcare, research and innovation

ecosystem for India. The project will see a global investment of USD 1.2 billion, spread over 250 acres, and is expected to create 10,000 jobs. Cleveland Clinic will be the anchor partner for the initiative, which aims to integrate world-class patient care with medical education, research, AI, genomics and innovation at scale. Expressing elation over the partnership, the Chief Minister said the MediCity would combine clinical excellence with cutting-edge



research and technology. "This is more than just a healthcare project. Together we shall create healing wonders," he said, congratulating Maharashtra and Bharat on the launch. According to Fadnis, the project aligns with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 'Heal in India' vision and marks a bold step towards establishing India as a global destination for healthcare, research and medical innovation. The signing coincided with Prime Minister Modi com-

pleting 4,399 days in office, noted as a record for the longest-serving elected Prime Minister. The MoU was signed in the presence of Cleveland Clinic CEO Dr Tomislav Mihaljevic, Dr Sameer Kapadia, Chairman of Cardiovascular Medicine, Board Member Lakshmi Mittal, Executive Chairman of Arcelor Mittal, and Dr Falcone, President of Emerging Markets, from Ohio, USA, along with officials from all partner organisations.

IIFL Home Finance partners to support blind cricket

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IIFL Home Finance, one of India's leading affordable housing finance companies, has partnered with the Cricket Association for the Blind in India (CABI) and Samarathanam Trust for the Disabled and CABI, to support and strengthen Cricket for the Blind in India.

As part of this collaboration, the organisations have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to organise the India-Nepal Bilateral Blind Cricket Series, featuring five T20 matches scheduled to be held in the Delhi-NCR region in October 2026.

The engagement aims to provide visually impaired cricketers with a competitive international platform while strengthening awareness of and participation in blind cricket across the country. Speaking on the initiative, Aarti Marwaha, Chief



Human Resource Officer, IIFL Home Finance, said, "At IIFL Home Finance, we believe in enabling opportunities that foster inclusion, confidence, and long-term community impact. Through our partnership with Samarathanam Trust for the Disabled and CABI, we are proud to support Cricket for the Blind and contribute to creating a stronger, more inclusive sporting ecosystem for visually impaired athletes. Sports has the power to inspire, empower, and drive meaningful social

change, and this initiative reflects our continued commitment towards inclusive community development." Speaking on the occasion, Dr Mahantesh G Kivadasannavar - Chairman of Cricket Association for the Blind in India, said, "Cricket for the Blind has emerged as one of the most powerful tools for empowering persons with visual impairment, providing them with opportunities for leadership, teamwork, confidence-building, and professional development".

Minister Ajanta Neog reviews DDC meeting in Kamrup

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amingaon

Assam's newly appointed Guardian Minister for Kamrup district, Ajanta Neog, on Wednesday chaired a review meeting of the District Development Committee (DDC) at the conference hall of the Integrated District Commissioner's Office, Amingaon.

Neog, who also holds the portfolios of Women & Child Development and Tourism, reviewed the functioning and progress of various developmental projects being implemented across the district. Emphasising efficient governance, the Minister directed officials to ensure that proposals are processed within 24 hours and that no work remains pending at any level. She urged all departments to adhere to project timelines while maintaining transparency, accountability and quality in the execution of government programmes, stress-

Gajraj Corps inspires 550 NCC Cadets with motivational weapon display

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Indian Army, under the aegis of Red Horns Division, Gajraj Corps, conducted a motivational weapon display on Wednesday for 550 NCC cadets undergoing Combined Annual Training Camp CATC-42 of 1 Assam Battalion NCC, Guwahati Group, at JNV Nalbari.

The display showcased the latest infantry weapons, small arms and equipment currently in service with the Armed Forces. Troops from Gajraj Corps explained technical features, operational

use and maintenance, giving cadets practical insight into the modernisation of the Indian Army. The event aimed to foster a deeper appreciation for the dedication and sacrifices of soldiers while inspiring youth towards patriotism, discipline and responsible citizenship. Interacting with troops, cadets displayed keen interest and enthusiasm, with many expressing aspirations to join the Armed Forces. The initiative reinforced NCC's core values of 'Unity and Discipline' and strengthened the bond between the Army and youth of Assam.



ing that developmental works should not compromise on standards under any circumstances. The Guardian Minister also instructed officials to share an overview of development activities and constituency-wise progress with the respective MLAs to facilitate better coordination and effective monitoring. The meeting was also attended by MLA (Kamalpur) Diganta Kalita, MLA (Chamaria)

Rekibuddin Ahmed, MLA (Hajo Sualkuchi) Prakash Chandra Das, District Commissioner Deba Kumar Mishra, Senior Superintendent of Police Subhasish Baruah, Chief Executive Officer of Kamrup Zila Parishad Siddhartha Goswami, District Development Commissioner Susanta Kumar Dutta, Additional District Commissioners, Co-District Commissioners and heads of various departments.

DAILY SUDOKU

7	3							
2	1			7				4
	9	8		4				
3			8		5	1		
	9	2		8				
	2	5	7					6
			3	1		4		
1		9			7		8	
				3			1	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

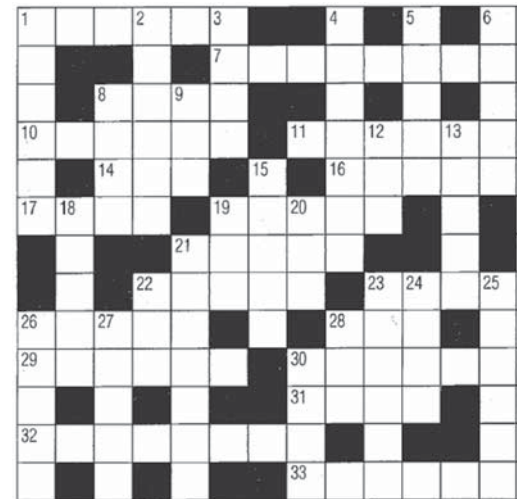
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (9.6.26)								
7	8	2	9	1	6	3	5	4
1	5	3	8	4	7	9	2	6
9	6	4	5	3	2	7	8	1
4	7	8	3	2	9	1	6	5
2	1	9	6	8	5	4	7	3
5	3	6	4	7	1	2	9	8
3	9	1	7	6	8	5	4	2
8	2	7	1	5	4	6	3	9
6	4	5	2	9	3	8	1	7

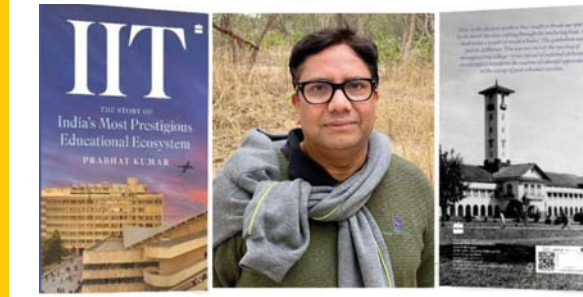
DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | JUNE 11, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 1 Hardy plant? Apparently not! (6)
7 For a start, it's musical (8)
8 It's rude to call a woman a swollen-headed convict! (4)
10 Size of a book or coat changed by Victor and Oscar (6)
11 Handy source of information (6)
14 All round, the London one has a focus of attention (3)
16 Eponymous, novel character (5)
17 Punishes for breaking a spare part (4)
19 Man going half a mile in a vessel (5)
21 Piece of timber usable as a brace (5)
- DOWN**
- 1 Being in power, work hard (6)
2 The stricken slayer passes on (6)
3 The identifying sign of a record circle (4)
4 A wave of destruction? (7)
5 Distressed at being made mincemeat of? (3,2)
6 Some are on wheels (5)
8 Set out quietly for a walk (4)
9 Eva's a little way back (3)
12 Silly fellow lacking wit (3)
13 Father turns to a boy for protection (5)
15 A bulk distribution of capital (5)
18 Of overseas origin, like Ian (5)
- 22 Did he become immortal by looking both ways? (5)
23 It can help control traffic when there's a storm warning (4)
26 Can a mere learner navigate on one? (5)
28 Step on the gas, my good man! (3)
29 Indisposed to take a bit of a gamble on a girl (6)
30 Scold a bad beater (6)
31 A botanist's angle? (4)
32 Superior to me in the newspapers, one imagines (8)
33 Relatively anxious to be more incisive (6)
- 19 Transportation north to Virginia (3)
20 The French boy (3)
21 Might such a charge make one cry aloud? (4,3)
22 An injection, yes, with British capital (3)
23 Ruddy price rise - possibly a rip off! (6)
24 Ground suitable for rugby football? (4)
25 Where there's no longer a blasted tree? (6)
26 Less than a pinta! (5)
27 An orange Adam never had? (5)
28 About to kiss a fellow (3)
30 Call at Beachy Head, just to enjoy the sunshine (4)

SOLUTION (10.6.26)					
ACROSS	19, Met-Ed	DOWN	15, Pin-up		
1, Grass	20, Last-ed	2, Rustic	16, Da-ll-y		
6, Space	22, Bull	3, Sco-use	18, Meth-s		
9, Cent-a-ur	24, Ye-t	4, SEI	19, Medical		
10, A-Sot	25, C-harp-oy	5, Strip(-e)	21, Aerial		
11, Gourd	26, Gi-Les	6, Sugared	22, Braine		
12, Hira-M	27, Mimic	7, Prom	23, Lovage		
13, Pit stop	28, Liliac	8, Car-bon	25, Cello		
15, P-od	29, Gal-Leon	12, H-Op,-e'd	26, Gi-Gi		
17, God's-Acre	30, Fia-ll	13, P-ally	28, Lop(-e)		
18, Medina	31, Peter(sham)	14, Tru-St			

New book chronicles IITs' journey from freedom struggle symbol to global innovation powerhouse



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A new book, IIT: The Story of India's Most Prestigious Educational Ecosystem, by Prabhat Kumar, IRS officer and Chairman of PanIIT Alumni India, offers a sweeping account of the evolution of the Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) from a post-Independence nation-building project to a globally influential educational and innovation ecosystem. The book traces the origins of the IIT movement to 1951, when the foundation stone of IIT Kharagpur was laid at the site of the former Hijli Detention Camp in West Bengal. The transformation of a colonial prison into a centre of learning was seen as deeply symbolic of India's future — a catalyst for scientific and technological progress.

Today, India's 23 IITs boast more than 500,000 alumni worldwide, many of whom occupy leadership positions in technology, business, government and academia. The book highlights IITians' contributions to landmark national initiatives, including Aadhaar, UPI, space missions, infra-

structure development, and the country's emerging artificial intelligence ecosystem. Kumar argues that the IIT story has entered a new phase marked by rapid expansion, the rise of a multi-billion-rupee coaching industry, growing mental health concerns, and a flourishing startup culture. The book examines these developments through a combination of personal narratives, data-driven analysis and policy insights. The book sheds light on deep-tech innovations emerging from IIT campuses, including advancements in space technology, agricultural intelligence, and Indian-language AI models. It also addresses the challenges facing students, including academic pressure and mental health struggles, while documenting efforts by institutions to strengthen support systems. Looking ahead to 2047, the book outlines an ambitious vision for IITs as global centres of research, innovation and talent, positioning them as key drivers of India's aspiration to become a developed nation.

President approves merger of REC with PFC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The President has approved the merger of REC Ltd with Power Finance Corporation (PFC), nearly seven years after PFC acquired the government's majority stake in REC. In March 2029, state-owned PFC completed the acquisition of the Government's majority stake of 52.63 per cent in REC Ltd for ₹14,500 crore. According to a regulatory filing by the REC, the Ministry of Power, vide its letter dated June 10, 2026, has conveyed the approval of the Competent Authority (President of India) in respect of the aforesaid proposal (merger of REC into PFC). On May 16, the Board of Directors at its meeting reserved the proposal for the

merger of REC into PFC in view of approval of the proposal by the President of India. Upon the merger being duly approved under the applicable law and being made effective, all the assets and liabilities of the REC will be transferred to PFC, and REC will stand dissolved in accordance with the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Companies Act 2013, REC had said. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, in her budget speech this year, had talked about the merger of REC and PFC. In order to achieve scale and improve efficiency in the Public Sector NBFCs, she had said, as a first step, it is proposed to restructure the Power Finance Corporation and REC (erstwhile Rural Electrification Corporation).



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BRIEFLY

Premier League: Sancho leaves Man United, Bissouma out at Tottenham



Manchester United winger Jadon Sancho and Tottenham midfielder Yves Bissouma are among the players being released by their Premier League teams at the end of their contracts. Sancho joined United from Borussia Dortmund for 85 million euros (\$100 million) in 2021 but has been underwhelming, only making 83 appearances during his five years there. He had loan spells in that time at Dortmund, Chelsea and most recently Aston Villa. United confirmed Wednesday that Brazil midfielder Casemiro and left back Tyrell Malacia were also leaving the team. Bissouma, a Mali international, moved to Tottenham from Brighton for 25 million pounds (\$30.5 million) in 2022 and played 111 times for the London club, including starting the Europa League final win over Man United in 2025. He has dropped down the pecking order of central midfielders during the past year.

Tottenham, which only survived relegation on the final day of the recently completed season, has given a new contract to defender Ben Davies.

Messi scores on a penalty as Argentina beats Iceland in World Cup tune-up



Lionel Messi is ready for his sixth World Cup. After recovering from a muscle injury, the captain of the reigning world champions played 20 minutes and scored a penalty in Argentina's 3-0 victory over Iceland on Tuesday in its final tune-up match before the World Cup. Messi, recovered from muscle fatigue and a slight strain in his left hamstring that he suffered in his last appearance with Inter Miami on May 24, started the game from the bench. Just days before his 39th birthday and his sixth World Cup, Messi came on in the 70th minute and he scored a penalty kick after Lautaro Martinez was fouled inside the area. Messi, the all-time top scorer for the Argentine national team with 117 goals, converted the penalty with a high left-footed shot in the 72nd minute.

Argentina, seeking its fourth World Cup title after those won in 1978, 1986, and 2022, will open its tournament against Algeria on June 16 in Kansas City in Group J, which also includes Austria and Jordan.

It was the second match between the two nations. The first one was at the 2018 World Cup, when the European side managed a 1-1 draw in which Messi missed a penalty.

Kochhar, Bhullar in 10-member Indian golf contingent for Morocco event

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Rabat (Morocco)

In excellent form with three top-10 finishes in just five Asian Tour starts this season, Karandeep Kochhar will lead a 10-member Indian contingent in the International Series Morocco golf tournament which will tee off on Thursday.

The other Indians in the USD 2 million event are Anirban Lahiri, Gaganjeet Bhullar, Aryan Roopa Anand, Udayan Mane, SSP Chawrasia, Rashid Khan, Shaurya Bhattacharya, Ajeetesh Sandhu and Shubham Jaglan



The 26-year-old Kochhar was tied ninth at last week's AM Green IGPL Bharath Classic, after a tied fifth at International Series Japan and fourth place at the Philippine Golf Championship. Late last year, he won the Egypt Golf Series Red Sea Open on the Asian Development Tour.

"I think I've been playing really well this year. I've only played five events so far and I've already had three top-10 finishes, so that's definitely encouraging," said a confident Kochhar. "Even in the other events, I felt like I was playing solid golf. In New Zealand, I just had a poor Sunday, and in Singapore I wasn't playing my best, but I still managed to make the cut, which I was happy about."

That consistency has been tested over the past three weeks as Kochhar competed throughout Morocco's unique professional golf swing, progressing from the Asian Development Tour and Asian Tour to this week's International Series Morocco.

The 2026 World Cup: Football at the Centre of a Changing World



SHAKYA MITRA

The 2026 FIFA World Cup starting on June 11 promises to be unlike any tournament the sport has witnessed before. Expanded to 48 teams and hosted primarily in the United States alongside Canada and Mexico, the competition arrives at a moment when football is increasingly intertwined with geopolitics, generational change, and the globalisation of the game. Beyond the spectacle on the pitch, this World Cup could redefine how international football is experienced and remembered.

One of the most emotional narratives surrounding the tournament will almost certainly be the possibility that it represents the final World Cup appearances of two of football's defining figures Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo.

For nearly two decades, Messi and Ronaldo have been the dominant forces in the sport. Their rivalry shaped an era, elevating standards of performance, longevity, and global popularity. The 2026 tournament may provide the closing chapter to that story on football's biggest stage.

For Messi, 39, who plays his club football in the USA with Inter Miami and already a World Cup winner after Argentina's triumph in 2022, the tournament could be less about legacy and more about celebration. For audiences in the stadium as well



as those watching in their homes, the feeling of watching Messi in possibly his last World Cup will carry a enormous sense of nostalgia.

For Portugal's Ronaldo the stakes could be all the more dramatic. 41 years old and still scoring goals aplenty in the Saudi League, the very fact that he is even here is an extraordinary feat of endurance and professionalism. This World Cup will give him one final chance to chase the one major trophy that has eluded him.

If all goes to plan, these two legends could face off at the quarterfinal stage and that will be indeed a spectacle for millions of football enthusiasts.

At the opposite end of the spectrum, is 19 year-old boy wonder Lamine Yamal of Spain, who will have the eyes of the world on him. Having already played a pivotal role in his country's 2024 European Championship title, he could leave a bigger imprint if he can repeat it at the World Cup.

Though the expansion to 48 teams has not come without its critics, it creates one of the tournament's greatest opportunities, the inclusion of nations that previously stood outside foot-

ball's elite circle. Debutants Curaçao, Cape Verde, Uzbekistan, and Jordan would bring entirely new football cultures to the global stage. Their participation would underline how much the sport has evolved beyond its traditional power centres in Europe and South America.

For these countries, qualification itself is historic. Smaller footballing nations often arrive with fewer expectations but enormous emotional energy, and that can transform the atmosphere of a tournament.

The World Cup will take place mainly in the United States amidst a charged political environment. In the wake of tensions between the US and Iran, this tournament could become a stage where sport and international politics intersect more visibly than any other World Cup in recent memory. There is also a reasonably realistic possibility of USA and Iran clashing in the Round of 32, if the two nations finish as runners-up in their respective groups.

One of the most exciting modern World Cup trends has been the rise of nations previously considered outsiders.

Croatia reached the 2018

final. Morocco made history in 2022 by becoming the first African side to reach the semifinals. Earlier tournaments saw South Korea, Turkey, and Uruguay reach the last four.

These performances are no longer the miraculous exceptions they might have once been viewed as. The global football landscape has become more balanced than at any point in history. Players beyond the stronger nations now compete regularly in Europe's top leagues, gaining elite tactical and technical experience.

With the expansion to 48 teams, the tournament's length has already been called into question. 40 matches more than the previous editions since 1998 and on some instances four matches being played in a single day.

How the 2026 World Cup fares will represent a test case for the future of international football itself. If this format succeeds, it could permanently alter expectations for global tournaments with talk of World Cups in the future expanding to 64 teams.

The expanded size of the World Cup, the length, the political tension and more pertinently the potential World Cup swansong of some of the legends of Football, make the 2026 World Cup a defining event. One can only hope that it provides us with what it always has unpredictability, emotional drama and perhaps even an upset or two to liven up the tournament.

(Writer is a sports management consultant. He works across both the private and the Government sectors.)

Sindhu cruises, Tanvi stuns fifth seed opponent as Indian women shine in Australian Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Sydney

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu led a strong show by Indian women with an easy victory while teenager Tanvi Sharma pulled off an upset win in the women's singles competition at the Australian Open Super 500 badminton tournament here on Wednesday.

Third seed Sindhu, Tanvi, Malvika Bansod, Isharani Baruah and Tanya Hemanth all progressed to the round

of 16, but it was a disappointing day for the Indian men with Kiran George, Tharun Manneppalli and qualifier Saneeth Dayanand bowing out in the opening round.

Sindhu barely broke a sweat in her opener, outclassing Peru's Ines Lucia Castillo Salazar 21-13, 21-11 in just 32 minutes.

The former world champion was in complete control throughout the contest, dominating the rallies and never allowing her opponent to settle into a rhythm.



Sindhu will next face compatriot Isharani, who fought hard to overcome China's Han Qian Xi 22-20, 10-21, 21-14 in a one-hour three-minute

battle. The biggest result of the day came from 17-year-old Tanvi, who upset fifth seed and world No. 11 Chiu Pin-Chian of Chinese Taipei

21-12, 22-20 in 45 minutes.

World No. 36 Tanvi will now take on fellow Indian Malvika in the round of 16 after the latter recovered from a game down to beat Thailand's Tonrug Saeheng 15-21, 21-7, 21-13.

Tanya also joined the winning brigade, defeating Ishika Jaiswal of the USA 21-17, 21-18 in 39 minutes. She will face world No. 8 and second seed Pompaewee Chochuwong of Thailand in the next round.

Indian men disappoint

In the men's singles,

George suffered a hard-fought 19-21, 21-14, 15-21 defeat to Malaysia's Justin Hoh in a match that lasted one hour and two minutes.

Qualifier Dayanand found the going tough against China's Hu Zhe'an, losing 8-21, 10-21 in just 35 minutes.

Tharun came closest to causing an upset, pushing second seed and world No. 10 Lin Chun-Yi of Chinese Taipei to the limit before going down 21-18, 13-21, 23-25 in a gripping one-hour 20-minute contest.

Atletico Madrid rejected 150 million euros offer for Julian Alvarez: Real Madrid

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Real Madrid says city rival Atletico Madrid has rejected an offer of 150 million euros (\$173 million) for Argentina forward Julian Alvarez.

The offer was part of the campaign promises made by Real Madrid President Florentino Perez, ahead of his re-election on Sunday.

The 15-time European champion said that, "After reviewing and evaluating the offer, Club Atletico de Madrid has expressed its gratitude for the proposal, made within the framework of the good relations between both clubs, and has rejected it, referring to the player's release clause." Spanish media reported that this was 500 million euros (\$577 million).

Real Madrid endured a second straight season without a major trophy.

Also Tuesday, it parted ways with



coach Alvaro Arbeloa, who had replaced Xabi Alonso in January. The move sets up the expected return of Jose Mourinho.

Benfica says Mourinho has agreed to move to Real Madrid after Arbeloa departure announced

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Benfica said late Tuesday that its coach Jose Mourinho had agreed to return to Real Madrid, which earlier announced that it had parted ways with coach Alvaro Arbeloa.

Madrid President Florentino Perez had vowed to bring Mourinho back as part of his campaign promises that led to his re-election on Sunday.

In a note to shareholders, Benfica said that Madrid had formally agreed to pay Benfica 15 million euros (\$17.3 million) for Mourinho with the Portuguese coach agreeing to the move.

Benfica added: "Thank you,



Jose Mourinho." Madrid has made no official announcement. Mourinho, who was featured in promotional material for Perez during the campaign, would be back for a second stint at Madrid. He coached the club from 2010-2013. Arbeloa's departure was already expected and he had talked about it at the end

of the season.

Madrid said Tuesday it was "deeply grateful" to Arbeloa, "who throughout his career at the club, from the time he joined our academy, has always demonstrated loyalty, commitment, and professionalism."

Arbeloa took over the helm in January to replace

Xabi Alonso amid the team's struggles.

Arbeloa was not able to put Madrid back on track and the club endured a second straight season without a major trophy.

Last month, Arbeloa gave his blessing to former boss Mourinho's return to Madrid, saying he would "be happy to see him back home."

Arbeloa played for Madrid when Mourinho was in charge of the club - a tumultuous time in which Madrid won Spanish league and Copa del Rey titles but was overshadowed by Pep Guardiola's great Barcelona side. Mourinho's abrasive attitude to opponents like Guardiola as well as some of his own players turned off many in Spain.

Somali World Cup referee denied entry to US arrives home to hero's welcome

OMAR FARUK ■ Mogadishu (Somalia)

A World Cup referee from Somalia who was denied entry to the United States was received by a crowd of supporters and officials Wednesday as he arrived in Somalia's capital of Mogadishu, where he said he plans to be at the next World Cup and urged Somali youths to be proud of their country.

Omar Artan was set to be the first referee from Somalia to officiate at a World Cup after making FIFA's final list for the tournament. He is one of Africa's top referees and was named the continent's best male referee in 2025.

He was denied entry at Miami International Airport on

Saturday over "vetting concerns," US Customs and Border Protection said in a statement without giving details of those concerns. FIFA subsequently cut him from the tournament's referee list.

Artan was issued a visa to travel to the US last week, according to the Somalia Embassy in Kenya that processed it. US is co-hosting with Mexico and Canada, and Artan was due to meet up with other World Cup referees at their training base in Miami.

He returned to a hero's welcome at the airport in Mogadishu, where he thanked the Somali government and people as well as FIFA for their support for him.

"I promise you, God willing,



that I will attend the next one," he said as hundreds of supporters at the airport waved the Somali flag. "I want the Somali public to take comfort in this and remain confident."

The US's highly unusual move to deny a FIFA-appointed match official permission to enter a

World Cup host country drew outrage across the world and raised questions among some fans about America's capacity to host the competition.

Somalia is one of nearly 40 countries subject to new travel restrictions under the Trump administration's crackdown on

immigration.

Hundreds of supporters, government officials and members of Somalia's football community gathered hours before Artan arrived at Aden Adde International Airport at about 8.30 am local time. As Artan disembarked, supporters waving Somali flags crowded around him before draping him in the flag.

He was then escorted by police officers to the airport's VIP terminal, where he was welcomed by Somalia's Minister of Youth and Sports, officials from the Somalia Football Federation and other dignitaries and spoke to press.

"It is up to all of us to defend the Somali name," Artan said. "Somalia belongs to us, whether it is in a bad state or a good state.

That flag belongs to us, and that passport belongs to us."

In a country where decades of war and the rise of the al-Qaida-linked al-Shabab extremist group has limited the potential of many, Artan's denial brought disappointment to many but reminded some in the country about what is possible if they chase their dreams.

Artan's expected milestone at this year's World Cup "stands no matter what," the World Health Organization Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus wrote Tuesday on X. "You reached the summit of your profession and inspired a generation back home just by getting there, and being kept off the pitch you earned doesn't change that," he added.

Pant must curb flamboyance, fix vulnerable temperament: Kirmani

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former India cricketer Syed Kirmani says wicketkeeper-batter Rishabh Pant needs to check his flamboyance, work on his physical fitness and “vulnerable” temperament if he wishes to play all formats for the country again.

The 28-year-old Pant, who was touted as a natural all-format player, features in Tests only in the past two years, though he plays in T20 cricket in the Indian Premier League. “Rishabh has to work hard on his physical fitness, consistency and temperament. His temperament is very vulnerable, turbulent. No player can say ‘I am a born hitter, I have to hit

every ball’. You might have that particular day when you get rid of every ball you want to hit.

But you have to look into the circumstances, what format you are playing, and what the team wants you to do,” Kirmani said in an exclusive interview.

“Wherever Rishabh Pant is selected, he has to show his physical fitness, he has to show his performance. He has to show his consistency is better than the other wicketkeepers competing with him. That’s it.”

Kirmani described Pant as the “most gifted and talented” player to emerge in Indian cricket “after Sachin Tendulkar and before



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi”. “When Rishabh Pant broke into the Indian side, I thought he was the most talented or gifted after Sachin Tendulkar. And I considered him the most talented until this new boy (Vaibhav) Sooryavanshi emerged. But

now when I see him playing only Tests, I am quite baffled,” said the former wicketkeeper-batter.

He said the coaches and mentors can guide and show a cricketer the right direction and approach, but ultimately it’s the player who has to

perform, and he can’t blame anybody if he does not succeed. “The coaches, the mentors who are around, their duty is to guide and show the player the right direction and approach.

Before a match starts, they can only guide the players,” said 76-year-old Kirmani who played 88 Tests and 49 ODIs between 1976 and 1986.

“You can’t blame anybody else. It has to be the player all the way, whether he or she shows a good form or not. Nobody can take the blame except the player himself,” he observed.

In December 2022, Pant was seriously injured in a horrific car crash but he returned to action 15 months later, in

the IPL 2024. “It’s the unfortunate accident which he went through. In that process, all other wicketkeepers in the making came up one after another.

They showed consistency in Test matches and ODIs wherever they were selected. They showed their ability to perform when it is required. “So, in that process, Rishabh Pant lost his little ground there during the recuperation of his accident. Now, he faces tremendous competition,” the 1983 World Cup winner said.

“After the near fatal accident...it was a huge comeback for him. And he’s taking some time. He is not showing that kind of consistency he

had shown earlier in all the three formats,” he remarked. Kirmani said there’s a lot of competition to get into the Indian team in all formats, and not only Pant, all the players will have to be at their best to get selected. “There is fierce competition among players, be it a medium pacer, spinner or a batter or a wicketkeeper. Now, the selection committee is having a huge problem in selection of wicketkeeper-batter or batter who can keep wickets.

Rishabh is back, KL Rahul is there, Dhruv Jurel, Ishan Kishan and Sanju Samson is there. They are in the ODIs and T20s. There is fierce competition among these

five players,” Kirmani said. “Every player has to be on their toes, not only Rishabh Pant, because there is so much talent and in all these wicketkeepers who are in the frame. So, Rishabh has to be on his toes all the times,” he added

“You’ve got to consider that particular player’s consistency and physical fitness for selection. That’s the way to select that player. The current breed of wicketkeepers and batters are concentrating more on their batting prowess because if they score and provide significant batting support, they advance. They are concentrating more on their batting ability,” he concluded. (PTI)

Manav Suthar to play for Warwickshire in English County Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar, who starred in India’s win against Afghanistan in the recent one-off Test, has signed with English club Warwickshire for the next two rounds of the County Championship.

Warwickshire on Wednesday announced the signing of Suthar on a short-term contract. It said he will be available for selection for the next two rounds of the Rotherham County Championship — the game against Yorkshire at Scarborough from June 12-15 June and the next fixture against Somerset at Taunton the following week.



Suthar, a left-arm finger spinning all-rounder, made his Test debut for India in the one-off Test against Afghanistan in New Delhi which ended on Monday, and announced his arrival on the international stage by taking six for 33 in the first innings and 1-29 in the second.

Gurnoor Brar: Gentle giant who took up cricket at 17 and got picked for India at 26

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Chandigarh

When Sukhbir Singh Brar came to know that his teenaged son Gurnoor was passionate about cricket, he was more than happy to give wings to his dreams for two reasons. One, he truly wanted to be a supportive father. Two, being an ASI in Punjab Police he thought of it as a perfect way to ensure that the 17-year-old stays away from “bad company”.

“As he was reaching late teens, I wanted my son to get into the sport apart from pursuing his studies so that he doesn’t have time to indulge in anything else,” Sukhbir recalled in an interview to PTI reflecting on his pacer son’s rise at his upscale residence in Chandigarh’s sector 125. “Also systematic coaching means you don’t keep any bad company. And moment Gurnoor joined Champs Academy under coach Ravi ‘sir’, he didn’t look back,” he said with a smile.

Gurnoor was a lanky boy who



took up cricket in 11th standard. At 26, he is a part of India’s Test and ODI squads even though the national debut is yet to come. But Brar senior, who stands at an imposing 6 feet 4 inch which just an inch less

than Gurnoor, is quite confident of his son’s bright future.

“I am a Policeman but I get more emotional than Gurnoor’s mother (Manvinder). When we got the news of his India selection, I liter-

ally had tears in my eyes,” Brar senior, who represented Punjab in the 1995 National Basketball Championship, The Brar family got the news from their son in a very matter of fact manner.

“The day the squad for Afghanistan Test was announced, we were at my ancestral home in Muktsar Sahib due to a death in the family. Now Gurnoor, if he had evening practice during IPL, would go off to sleep in afternoon and always tell his mom to wake him up around 4:45 pm.

“So my wife called to wake him up and asked, ‘Wasn’t there team announcement today?’ ‘Oh yes Mama, I have been selected’ is all he said before keeping the phone down,” Sukhbir laughed.

“My son has always been like that. He doesn’t go overboard with anything. Very reserved, apne kaam se kaam rakhnewala ladka hai woh (believes in minding his own business).” He remembered how Gurnoor took up cricket quite late compared to other kids, who

are sent to academies by the time they are 9 or 10 years old. “Being a policeman, I hardly had time during their (his two sons) growing up years. After Gurnoor completed his 10th standard board exams, I made him try basketball since that was the sport I played and height is something we are blessed to have.

“Gurnoor tried it for two-three weeks but he told me ‘Papa I am not enjoying’,” he recalled. Unlike the 1970s, ‘80s and ‘90s, university cricket isn’t the most dynamic in India but Gurnoor’s first big break was representing DAV College Chandigarh in an inter-college tournament where he got Player of the match award in both the semi-final and final. “My son, despite his cricket commitments, got 80 per cent in Arts in 12th standard and got into DAV College on sports quota. He had a role in DAV College’s triumph and was supposed to play the International College tournament to be held in Dubai,” Sukhbir said. (PTI)



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